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VERSATILE HUNTING DOG

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Our Way of Saying “Thank You”

In celebration of NAVHDA's continued growth, we are excited to bring you a bonus issue of the VHD focused exclusively on training! It's a way of saying “Thank You” to all of our new members for choosing NAVHDA, and to all of our more experienced members for their continued support. The key to NAVHDA's extraordinary success has been the hard work, enthusiasm, and talent of our membership. Thanks for making NAVHDA what it is: the finest dog training organization in the world!

At its heart, NAVHDA is a grass-roots organization composed of volunteer members just like you who are dedicated to helping one another train their dogs. If you've been around for even a short time, you've found that many people use different techniques to achieve their goals. This special issue is composed of a variety of training articles previously published in the VHD. These articles are in no way meant to represent “The NAVHDA Way” of training, because there is no one method that works for every dog and every handler. For every method

described in any of these articles, there are several other methods that work just as well. And for those that have been around long enough to have training methods you've developed yourself, we're sure they're going to be somewhat, or even radically, different than those described in these articles. That's not just okay – that's great! We hope you use these articles not as a “how-to” manual but rather as a source of ideas that you can adapt to your own situation.

The quality of any finished product, whether it's a house, a business, or a hunting dog, is dependent on the strength of its foundation. With that in mind, the articles in this issue have been roughly organized to focus on different stages of development, from puppies to finished gun dogs. We hope these articles can serve as a rough guide to help both new and experienced members get the most out of their hunting partners.

~ NAVHDA Executive Committee

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It's A Brave New World!

By Judy Zeigler

Your new puppy will arrive soon, and you are anxiously waiting with a desire to start training as soon as possible. There are many resources available to help and, hopefully, this article will as well.

Let's start with the critical periods in your puppy's development.

Neonatal Period (birth-12 days)

Puppy cannot regulate body functions and relies on the mother and/or the breeder for elimination and temperature regulation.

Transition Period (13-20 days)

Ears and eyes open. Hearing and eyesight are very poor. Puppy moves about more and begins to control bodily functions.

Awareness Period (21-28 days)

Puppy is moving around in their environment well. Eyesight and hearing function well.

Canine Socialization Period (21-49 days)

Puppy learns to interact with littermates and his mother. Puppy interacts more with outside stimuli.

Human Socialization period (7-12 weeks)

Puppy learns by association. Permanent human bonding begins. Puppy goes to new home and begins house-breaking. Puppy now has the ability to learn simple behaviors such as recall, sit, down.

Fear Impact Period (8-11 weeks)

What puppy learns in this period is permanent. Avoid frightening experiences as they can have a negative effect. Experiences must be positive to minimize adverse conditioning.

Seniority Classification Period (13-16 weeks)

At this age puppy begins testing independence. Puppy is teething and may show biting behavior. Praise for correct behavior is very important.

Flight Instinct Period (4 to 8 months)

Teething continues at this time. Puppy shows strong independence. During this period it is critical to shape positive behavior while minimizing negative behavior.

Second Fear Period (6-14 months)

Fear of different situations manifest in this period. New situations should be handled with patience while avoid-

ing reinforcing negative behavior. Focus should be on building confidence.

Let's now explore how we can positively handle these periods and start puppy on a road to success.

'Socialization'

The idea behind socialization is helping puppy to become acclimated to all types of situations, sounds and smells in a positive manner. The key word is positive. According to the American Veterinary Society of Animal Behavior, improper socialization can impact behavior for that dog's entire life.

The world is brand new to your puppy and can be strange and unusual. Our job is to help them explore and create positive associations.

Avoid doing too much too fast. Start by introducing puppy to a few people at a time versus taking them

to a huge party. Start with positive training puppy classes. These help accustom puppy to other dogs and people.

Introduce puppy to many different people, places and other dogs. Introduce them to many different surfaces such as pavement, plastic, slippery floors, even a ladder or wire crate laid flat. Much research shows that in the first four months of life, exposing the puppy to any and all they may encounter in life will pay off greatly in a well-adjusted adult dog. Again, these must be positive experiences. Inadvertently, if a negative experience occurs such as the puppy being frightened by another dog or person, turn the situation around by tossing some high value treats away from the adverse event and try to distract the pup. Do your best to turn this into a somewhat positive situation. Do not coddle the pup nor force the situation. Act normally and walk away while redirecting





the pup into a more normal/positive behavior i.e. “sit and watch.”

Independence Training

Responsible breeders of sporting dogs will counsel their puppy buyers on the importance of independence training. Sporting dogs may have a tendency towards separation anxiety, and this can be avoided right from the time you bring puppy home. Set aside time during the day when puppy is required to be alone for an hour or so. A crate should be set up in a room where no human shall reside during the time frame set aside for the independence training. A radio may be played softly along with a Kong toy filled with peanut butter or easy cheese. Puppy should be steered towards the crate with a soft command of “kennel” while tossing a high value treat inside the crate. Close the door to the crate and leave for a period of 15 to 30 minutes. Puppy learns to cope on their own and realizes you will return. Upon return do not praise puppy, open door very quietly and take puppy outside to eliminate. It is important to note that if puppy is barking, waiting until they are quiet reinforces the behavior that quiet=door opens. Time spent alone in the crate, kennel or vehicle can gradually be increased.

Operant Conditioning

Dog training happens through operant conditioning. This is the way a dog learns or is conditioned from the way the dog behaves or operates in its environment. The change in the behavior will occur more or less depending

on positive and negative results. When you take puppy out into the field and feed him treats for sitting you are using operant conditioning. Reward based training has been shown to be an effective way to change behavior and emotion in dogs.

Positive Reinforcement

Positive reinforcement occurs when a motivating item such as a treat or verbal praise is presented after your pup exhibits a desired behavior. Using positive reinforcement will mean the desired behavior will most likely happen again.

Negative Reinforcement

Taking something unpleasant away from the dog the instant they perform the desired behavior. Negative reinforcers can be used to shape behavior. The ear pinch is an example of negative reinforcement. The trainer stops pinching the ear when the dog grabs a hold of an object. I am not advocating for the use of pain. We do not need to use pain and discomfort to achieve a high level of training. Another example of negative reinforcement can be pushing on a dog’s body to get it to move over, when the dog moves the forceful push is stopped.

Extinction Options

This method is used when you want your puppy to stop doing something i.e. jumping on people or begging at the table. The only way to stop these undesirable behaviors is to totally ignore (extinction) the puppy until he understands the behavior will get no reward. You must be consistent.

Shaping Behaviors

Shaping behavior is a training technique that builds on ‘capturing.’ Capturing is a training technique in which you wait for pup to show a behavior (sit and look up) and immediately reward when it happens. The use of rewards makes the behavior (sit and look up) happen more often, which enables you to add a word or command i.e. “watch” or “pay attention.” I like to use a clicker to mark the behavior I am capturing. The clicker has a sound the puppy doesn’t usually hear in everyday life, it is quick and consistent.



Positive vs. Negative Reinforcement

Science has proven that to effectively change behavior there has to be some type of motivation. Punishment will inhibit the developing bond between you and your puppy and can cause avoidance, depression and behavior problems. In using positive methods along with rewards you are strengthening the bond and developing a confident, happy, well-adjusted dog. Reward based training is not only scientifically sound, it will create a deeper bond between you and your puppy.

VHD, MAY 2018

Preparing a Puppy for a Natural Ability Test

Adapted from an article by John Kegel, NAVHDA Newsletter, August 1975

The following article has been adapted from one written by founding member John Kegel, was first published in Pudelpointer Club of North America newsletter, and subsequently in The NAVHDA Newsletter in August 1975. By “adapted from” we mean altered slightly in two specific ways. First, the original article focused on training a specific breed within NAVHDA (Pudelpointers); however, since the concepts presented here apply to all breeds within NAVHDA, we have removed a couple of breed-specific references. Indeed, as Mr. Kegel describes at the end of his article, “Although this article refers to training of a PP pup, there is no reason that these lessons cannot be used for every breed.” Second, the article has been shortened somewhat to remain focused on the broad aspects of Natural Ability preparation.

Finally, while this article was published over 45 years ago, the foundational principles haven’t changed much! Although many of us may use electronic bird releasers to accomplish what was once done with just birds, these techniques will work well—assuming you have birds that fly well. And, as always, there is no hard and fast rule on the age to begin specific aspects of training; the recommendations provided here are Mr. Kegel’s own rough guidelines which may or may not apply to your particular pup.



Those who think natural ability should surface by itself, and dogs entered in Natural Ability Tests don’t need any preparation should think again.

One question I am often asked by new puppy owners is: At what age should I start with the training and how much training does he need? Under my approach, training can start right from weaning and continue until the dog retires from hunting. Only the intensity and frequency of training will vary with the age of the dog.

From weaning to four or five months we might restrict our training to play training. Then after our pup’s hunting instinct has been fully developed, we can progress with an intensive training program. But even the fully trained dog will require some maintenance training from time to time.

I would like to divide the developing and preparation of our pup into three major phases:

Phase I: Play training or preliminary training and introducing our pup to the water. Age period – 7 weeks to approximately 5 months.

Phase II: Building and developing his hunting desire which will include search and pointing.

Phase III: Tracking.

PHASE I: PRELIMINARY TRAINING

- 1) Get the puppy used to his name and make him wear a (leather/nylon) collar.
- 2) Make him understand the meaning of the words No, Quiet, and Kennel.
- 3) Teach Sit, Stay, and Come. I don’t teach Whoa, Down, or Force Fetch at this stage.

All of my lessons are preceded by a five-minute play period to give the pup a chance to get rid of some of his excess steam. The playing consists of throwing a small dummy a few times out on the lawn and letting him retrieve it, or I take my fly rod with a pheasant wing dangling from it and let the pup chase it and point it a few times. I’m not convinced that sight pointing a pheasant wing does much for the pup’s future pointing, but, if not overdone, it is fun to watch the pup and also good exercise in a confined area.

The five-minute play period is followed by about 10 minutes of actual training, then I take the pup for a 15 minute romp in the field.

(continued...)

PHASE II: BUILDING AND DEVELOPING THE HUNTING DESIRE

This is the most important lesson for your puppy. At the same time, it is also the slowest and least interesting period for the novice dog trainer. Searching and pointing are natural instincts for our puppies, but we must provide our dogs with the opportunity to have these instincts developed.

I feel it is very important to get the pup to hunt instead of running only. In order to do that, we must provide the youngster with live bird contacts from the beginning on. Very few of us live in an area where wild birds are abundant so you must do the next best thing. Go to the game breeder and buy 20 *well flying* bobwhite quail. This may seem costly, but you have to realize a well-trained dog does not come cheap.

Now you'll need to find a field with suitable cover 5" to 10" tall. Take two or three of your quail and place them in some bird looking cover. Go back, get the pup, release him with a command, and walk a brisk pace, always facing the wind at the start. Until he learns what game-holding cover looks like, it may take a little bit of maneuvering at first to get your dog to the birds.

Don't expect a point right away. He will most likely show signs of making game by lowering his head and wagging his tail, flushing the bird and chasing it. This is normal and nothing to worry about (Editor's note: This is why you need birds that fly well!). After several flushes he will become more cautious and start to stalk and then point his game. *When your pup is approaching game he should be allowed full freedom. He should be permitted to make his point without directions or cautioning from you. This advice is not easy to follow. The handler's first impulse when he sees his dog slow down and go in with nose extended is to "whoa" and caution him at every stop.* This just slows up the dog and keeps him pottering around. *For these reasons I do not teach my dogs to whoa in Phase I. The temptation to use it in the field at an early age is too great.* Once your pup is holding point long enough for you to approach him, flush the bird and let him chase. You can take advantage of the chase by getting the dog used to gunfire – simply fire a cap pistol when the dog is about 30-40 yards away actively chasing the bird.

Field lessons should last about 20 minutes. Fifteen or twenty trips over a period of two months should bring your pup a long way in his development. His search should be aggressive and he should be pointing regularly.

PHASE III: TRACKING

There are many rules and techniques about training tracking, but it is not the purpose of this article to deal with the actual training procedures. For this reason, I will restrict my comments to a few general ideas.

Training tracking is relatively easy and does not require many lessons. We need a 50-yard strip of low grassy cover not over 4" tall and a pheasant with flight feathers pulled from one wing. You should choose the cooler hours of the day. You can either drag the pheasant using a pole so you don't leave foot scent on the bird's track, or simply release the pheasant. It is advisable to use a distinct command such as find, dead bird, fetch dead, trail, track, or whatever you like. Some dogs will track like they have done it all their lives, others will track a short distance and then try to search with a high head. Let him work the entire track (build up to 100 yards). If he does a reasonable job tracking, I would leave it at that and discontinue the lessons. Tracking, I feel, if overdone can have a detrimental effect on your search.

The speedster that wants to do the tracking with his legs rather than his nose needs lots of calming down. A failure to track is more often the result of the dog's relying more on speed than his nose.

Now good luck, and find a place on the wall for your plaque!

VHD, JUNE 2019



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Introduction To Tracking

By Chip Bonde

At many Natural Ability tests, I often hear handlers say to the judging team, “My dog has never seen a pheasant,” or, “my dog has never done a track.” The Natural Ability test is designed to evaluate seven inherited characteristics: nose, search, water, pointing, desire to work, cooperation and tracking. On page 11 of the 2014 edition of NAVHDA’s *Aims, Programs, Test Rules* it states, “Owners should not fall into the trap of telling themselves that because the Natural Ability Test emphasizes inherited abilities, preparation of the dog is not necessary.” Preparation is necessary! Whether you call this preparation simply exposure or training, I believe all dogs entered in a Natural Ability test should have been exposed to game in the field, the sound of gun shots, water (swimming) and tracking.

At what age should you start? I expose my litters of pups to live birds (usually quail) early, somewhere around six to seven weeks. Pups at this age are usually out of the whelping box, exploring everything that you allow them to. The fenced backyard is a great playground for exploring grass, shrubs, flowers, trees and even a goldfish pond. A wing clipped quail can be released to allow the pups to establish dominance over the bird. As the pups age, you can drop a chukar with the flight feathers pulled from one wing. Adult chukars will usually run, flap and try to escape. Without giving commands (it is way too early for that) you can simply walk in the direction the running chukar went. The pups will follow and try to locate the bird. This early exposure for the pups allows them to use their eyes along with their nose to try and catch the bird. Yes, hopefully we are building desire. As the pups age you might simply drag a dead bird, a quail, chukar, pheasant or duck. Again, without command, simply walk the pup across the track. When the pup indicates, calmly turn in the direction of the drag. Calmly walk at the dog’s pace toward the dead bird. When the pup arrives at the bird, let him or her pick it up as the reward. Do not be in a hurry to take the prize from the

pup. We are building confidence in the dog, a sense of accomplishment, the successful use of its nose to find the bird.

I spend the next several months exposing my pup to various hunting environments, fields, woods and water (small streams and ponds). I release many strong flying chukars and pigeons from electronic traps for my dog to point and chase. I want to build my pup’s desire for birds.

As the Natural Ability test approaches, I use a combination of techniques to introduce my personal dog to the formal tracking sequence. I usually start three to four weeks prior to the test. I try to not overdo the tracking preparation. I do not want to take away from my dog’s ability to point birds.

First, I scout out a large field of winter wheat or a hay field with the cover that will allow the pheasant to run and leave a good scent trail, but not so high that the bird stops and hides. I have already pulled all the flight feathers from one wing of the pheasant. I previously attached a long, light, white ribbon to one leg of the bird. I walk out with my dog and the pheasant to the center of the field. I hold my dog tightly and throw the pheasant down. The pheasant runs off, and the dog goes crazy. When the pheasant is out of sight to me, I know the pheasant is out of sight to the dog. I release the dog. She runs to the last spot she saw the pheasant and then has to start using her nose to find (track) the bird. I know the direction the pheasant went with the help of the white ribbon. If the dog loses focus, I simply walk in the direction I saw the bird go. I try not to say anything. Hopefully the dog will find the bird without my interference.

For the second track, I go to the same field a couple of days later. This time I have someone else go to the center of the field, pull breast feathers and leave them on the ground. Again, the pheasant has the white ribbon attached for my benefit. The bird is released from the feather pile. I bring my dog up. I use a one inch wide



KEVIN BILLY © 2022

nylon slip lead, no buckles. I thread the slip lead under her collar from the rear and fold it back to my hand. I show her the pile of feathers (on the downwind side of the pile), take a step or two in the direction I am told the pheasant went and release the slip lead. I stand quietly (pray) and watch my dog track.

I usually do a third track similar to what the pup will experience during the Natural Ability test. No white streamer, often starting near the edge of the field going toward cover, a feather pile pulled as in the test. Remember to show your dog the feather pile on the downwind side of the pile. Take three to four steps in the direction the pheasant went before releasing your dog.

If this third track went well, I have finished my exposure preparation for the Natural Ability Track.

Another way to introduce a young dog to tracking is to have a healthy pigeon in an electronic release trap. Have your NA pup point the bird in the trap. Release the bird and let your pup chase the bird. When the pup realizes he cannot catch the pigeon, he will return to the general area of the trap. While the pup was off chasing the pigeon, pick up the trap and release a flightless pheasant (again a white streamer helps you follow the pheasant). Have a few of the pheasant’s feathers where the trap was located. The pup will re-

turn to the general location and begin using his nose to work out where the pigeon was and then transition to the pheasant track. After he is successful in this scenario, you can practice the standard NA track procedure.

I firmly believe that exposure to the various aspects of the Natural Ability test is your responsibility. You did your homework. You used NAVHDA’s vast resources: database of breeders, test records, local chapters, chapter training days and the chapter members to help you select your hunting partner for the next 12-plus years. It is now your turn to provide that new pup the opportunities to grow and develop into the finished hunting dog we all strive to own.

Author’s Note: None of these examples are exclusively mine. When I joined the Potomac Chapter of NAVHDA in 1984, my first mentors were Dan Fansler and Dan Carter, both NAVHDA Judges, hunters and experienced dog trainers willing to help the newcomer. Years later, I met Clyde Vetter and Jessica Lieffort. My training philosophies and techniques evolved. One of the great benefits of NAVHDA membership is the people you meet who are willing to share ideas and help you learn how to train your dog.

VHD, AUGUST 2015

To Swim Or Not To Swim, That Is The Question

By Tracy Harmeyer

The day is hot, the water is warm, the entry for the water is gradual and there is not much wind. Still, your pup will not swim. The pup goes in up to its chest and will not step off of the drop-off. Doesn't the pup understand there is a test in two months? It is time to be inventive! Swimming comes naturally to dogs, but the knowledge that they will float when they step off the drop-off sometimes takes some work.

The best time to introduce a pup to water is at eight to twelve weeks. They are small, so you can go in up to your knees, set them into the water and let them swim back to shore. You will notice that, before the puppy touches the water, the its legs will start moving as if swimming. You can also start younger. I know many breeders that take six-week-old pups and their dam down to the water and the pups will follow her in.

Sometimes pups are born in the fall and go home in the winter. You may be dealing with ice or cold water. If this happens, there will be no putting the puppy in the water until spring when the pup is a little older.

You can try to use another dog to encourage or make the pup jealous. Sometimes this works if the pup really likes to retrieve. I would recommend that you use two bumpers to make sure the pup has something to retrieve. Sometimes the pup learns that the older dog will do all the swimming, and they can wait on shore for the bumper.

If you have socialized the pup to the water, tried to make the pup jealous with another dog, tried swimming with your pup and nothing works, it is time to

apply a little force. This process also works if your pup does not like bumpers. No bumpers are needed at first. I put on waders or a swimming suit (if it is warm enough), and go in up to my waist or chest, depending on the size of the pup. I put a check cord on the pup and get it so that it is at the edge of the drop-off. I do not pull the puppy to me. I make it uncomfortable enough so the pup decides to jump off. To make the pup uncomfortable, I tug and release the check cord so the puppy gets uncomfortable standing there. Once the pup decides to leave the drop-off, I catch the pup and give lots of praise. Sometimes I have to pull the puppy towards me once it starts to swim. Then I face the puppy towards shore and let it swim to shore. I only give the pup enough slack so its feet can touch bottom, not enough to leave the water. I call the pup back to the edge of the drop-off, tug and release on the check cord and make it step off on its own again, and I catch the pup. I will keep repeating this until the pup will step off and swim to me without me tugging on the check cord.

When the pup is comfortable swimming to me, I stand at the drop-off next to the pup and throw a bumper a few feet into swimming depth water. If the pup does not want to go, I step off the drop-off and tell the pup to "Get it!" If the pup still will not go, I will tug the check cord a little. Once the pup starts swimming, I give lots of praise and try to get it over to the bumper that I threw. I will keep trying to get the pup to swim with me standing at the drop off next



to the puppy. Once the pup is confident and jumping off the drop off on its own, I will back up a little with each throw until I am standing at the shore.

If the pup does not like bumpers, "Get it!" now becomes the command to swim. When standing next to the pup at the drop off, I will give the bumper a short toss into swimming depth water and tell the pup to get it. The pup probably is not going to go. I hook my finger in the collar and give a little push to make the pup swim. I will praise a lot and maybe give the pup a treat when it comes back. Hot dog pieces work really well. As the pup gains confidence and will swim after the bumper when told to get it, I will start to take away the treat and just rely on praise. I will also start to get a little closer to the shore with each throw. If I throw the bumper and say, "Get it," and the pup will not go, I will say, "No!" I take the pup to the edge of the drop-off, hook my finger in the collar and make the pup swim. When the pup is swimming, I will give lots of praise and maybe a treat. The goal is to be on shore, throw a bumper, say, "Get it!" and the pup will go to the drop-off and swim.

The next day when I come to the water, I will start by standing at the drop-off with the pup and keep backing up with each throw until I am at the shore line. Each day I start by standing a little closer to the shore line. Eventually I am standing on the shore throwing a bumper.

There are a few things about this technique that need to be discussed. First, your pup may not be happy with you and/or the water. Additionally, you have to teach the pup to have confidence and that the pup can do it. Once the pup learns this, the pup will be happier and more confident. On that first day, you must make the pup aware that it can float and trust that you will catch it. If this is not accomplished, you will defeat your purpose. The pup will be more afraid of the water. You cannot quit with that first session until the pup is stepping off on their own and swimming to you. If you follow through with this training concept, you will have a confident swimmer and a happy hunter.

VHD, MAY 2019

Foundation

The Building Blocks to a Versatile Champion

By Mark Whalen

Webster's simple definition of foundation is, "Usually a stone or concrete structure that supports a building from underneath." So, how do we relate foundation and structure to dog training? The answer is elementary and critically important in what we do as dog trainers, especially if your end in mind is a Utility Prize I or a Versatile Champion. In my opinion, most dogs of this caliber have two very distinct characteristics; they have an excellent foundation, and they are very cooperative. As with any structure if the foundation is imperfect, and pressure is applied from above, the structure is likely to collapse and crumble. This is also very true in dog training. If the proper foundation is not present, and the dog receives any type of pressure, or is asked to do something out of their comfort zone, the results are generally not too good. Let's explore dog training foundation a little bit deeper.

My foundation begins prior to breeding. As I've said in many previous articles, do your research, use the NAVHDA database, buy the best pup you can from a reputable breeder, and try very hard not to make an emotional decision when picking your pup. Things have changed a great deal from the mid-80's when I first joined the Potomac Chapter. Back then there was very little foundation given to puppies—very little. The rule of thumb for us in those days was, "Let your puppy be a puppy," which translated to not doing very much with them, other than expo-

sure, for the first twelve months or so. We would give them a few birds, run them in Natural Ability around 14 or 15 months of age, and, most of the time, not think about force breaking until the dog was around two years of age. Utility dogs were usually run around five years of age and there were very few Prize I dogs back then, both in NA and UT. These days much has changed; the dogs are very well-bred, and we as trainers are much better, with much better information and resources available to us.

When I speak of foundation, I speak of many things that are involved in laying the building blocks. This all begins on the first day the new pup arrives at my house. For me it is very important to set the standards right away. The pup must learn many things in their new environment: they need to be able to accept confinement, they need to fully understand where they fit in to the pack and who the pack leader is (me). The pup also needs to fully understand what is acceptable behavior and what is not. The pup will need to understand praise, and be able to accept corrections. The pup will be loved, nurtured, developed and worked, but at no time babied. Good behavior will always be rewarded; bad behavior will be followed with instant corrections. I will make it as black and white as I possibly can, and I will try to avoid any gray areas at all costs. I will train from day

one in very short, simple sessions. I will be creating a work ethic at a very young age that will continue throughout the life of the dog. All these things are the "footers" of the foundation, and the most important and critical part of the entire structure.

My pups will go to fields right away, they will experience the smells, sights and sounds of all sorts of terrain and water. They will also be exposed to lots of people and other dogs. My pups will ride in the kennel like big dogs and with big dogs, never on my lap or the back seat. I am trying to build confidence and acceptance of different types of situations, terrain, weather conditions, places and people. We are training bird dogs here folks...hunting dogs; they

will need to travel and travel well. They will also be put in many different field and water situations that are new to them. It may be cold, hot, windy, icy, humid, frigid or just downright nasty. Bird dogs with the proper foundation will have the mental stability to overcome and persevere regardless of the conditions or how far they have traveled to get there. They will also have the mental stability to accept correction and pressure. Again, these are all examples of building blocks; everything that you do with your pup should build on your early foundations.

You can't train a bird dog without birds; seems elementary, right? I can't tell you how many people I see with puppies who either don't give them birds, give





them birds once every month or two, or show up to a training session with one or two birds...huh? How can you train a bird dog with one or two birds? The answer is you can't, not if you want to go to a very high level. Again, FOUNDATION! I am going to give them lots of birds...lots, and they will get them the first week I have that pup in my possession. I will manage how and when the pup gets birds, but he will get many. For me 75-100 prior to his NA test and I want to run NA around six to seven months of age. I want this pup to be able to put together a few things: I like birds, I can use my nose to find them, I'm a bird dog, and I really like the guy who keeps giving me these flying critters. As mentioned above, I "like" to run a pup in NA around six to seven months, sometimes the calendar prevents this. I want to run them early for two reasons: I want to get a hunting season under their belts with lots of wild birds and waterfowl opportunities, and then I want to force break as soon as hunting season ends.

I can't speak of foundation without speaking about force breaking. If you have laid the proper foundation, your dog should have the mental capacity and stability to get through force breaking just fine. If not, you will have a struggle on your hands and you will probably not be happy with the outcome. Force breaking is where the puppy stuff ends and the big dog stuff begins. Commit to it, don't take any shortcuts, and teach the dog to turn off pressure, praise lavishly. Force breaking, if done correctly will pay dividends to you, but if the proper foundation has not been laid prior to that it will be a struggle.

In closing just remember that the road to a VC or UT Prize I begins at day one. Everything you do should build upon the next. Good luck, good training, and most of all good hunting!!!

VHD, NOVEMBER 2016

Transitioning From NA to UT Training

By Mark Whalen

Prior to running the NA test I like to give my dogs lots of birds. As I've stated in many previous articles, don't be cheap with your birds. You can't train a bird dog without birds. I want them to be very confident and comfortable in the presence of game. When they are pointing intensely, and I can at least walk up to flush the bird before the dog breaks, I will shoot every fourth or fifth bird for them. I also want them to be 'fairly' steady. When I say 'fairly,' I mean that I want the dog to be at least steady to flush and, hopefully, steady to wing. I like to do this with a combination of traps and free birds. So, if you have not done this prior to your NA test, that is where I would start. After that will come the most difficult and most important thing you will ever do with your dog: force breaking.

I, along with many others, have written numerous articles on force breaking, so this will not be a "how-to" on force breaking. When you look at the UT test there are many opportunities for retrieving. Properly force breaking will be crucial to your success in a UT test. If this will be your first time force breaking, I would strongly suggest you solicit help from another member who knows how to do it properly and has trained multiple dogs at higher levels. If this is not an option, or if you believe force breaking is not something you can handle, I would suggest you send the dog out to a professional. Thankfully, NAVHDA has many excellent professional trainers in the ranks that can force break your dog. Quite frankly, force breaking isn't for everyone; newer people sometimes struggle and

toil with it, creating a lot of confusion and gray areas for the dog. Knowing when to hold em', when to fold em', when to push, and when to back off only comes with experience. When force breaking is done properly it will pay dividends to you in the future, when done improperly it will be an exercise in frustration. In my opinion, force breaking separates Prize I UT dogs from all the rest.

After force breaking, I will put my dog back in the field to revisit steadiness. I will let them break on the shot, but anything prior to the shot will not be acceptable. I will demand flawless retrieving and a clean finish on all birds, and I will expect excellent manners and heeling. Duck search training will now begin.

The second most important thing for a UT dog is duck search training. Please remember, if you're after a UT Prize I then you must earn a '4' in duck search. Again, we won't dive in to duck search training in this article, but the same general rules apply: find some help from someone who knows how to do it and consistently gets '4' duck searches. The same rule that applies to birds applies to ducks as well: don't be cheap on your ducks! Give your dog good, lively ducks, and lots of them.

I personally will never throw a duck from the bank, I will never use a dead duck, and I will rarely shoot from the bank. I want my dog getting multiple duck contacts every time he is in the water, with multiple retrieves and multiple ducks chased and shot. I get out there with them in a kayak, and then wean them off the boat after I build a duck-searching machine. I want to



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imprint on the dog that any piece of water I take him to is full of ducks... “Go get ‘em, and don’t come back here until you do.”

It’s much better to do duck search training once a month with six ducks, than it is to do it every week with one. Once or twice a week with four or five ducks is optimal. Yep... training a bird dog is expensive!

So, what’s next?

I will then put the dog back in field to clean up the entire steadiness sequence. The dog is already steady to flush and wing, getting him steady to shot and fall will not be difficult.

At the same time I will work in some drags, not too many, just a few. Drags are no problem for a dog that has been properly force broken. I will, of course, continue to demand flawless retrieving and excellent heeling.

So, now you have a dog that retrieves any type of bird, tears up his duck search, and is steady to flush, wing, shot and fall.

Now I will work on my blind sequence. Heeling is not a problem because you have set the expectation for excellent heeling during the force breaking process and continued to demand excellence. I will then work on the remaining by the blind sequence with the dog and the retrieve of duck. For this, and everything else, I try to train above the test. Sometimes I fire multiple shots at remaining by the blind six, eight, or even ten. I also add distractions at remaining by the blind—like birds coming out of traps, wingers going off, etc. The same is true for the duck retrieve sequence... multiple birds, multiple shots, multiple distractions. I try very hard to keep it fresh and keep it different in an effort to avoid boredom for the dog.

Good luck with your UT training!!

VHD, JUNE 2018

Utility Test vs. Utility Preparatory Test

SEARCH FOR DUCK

UT: Dog must remain with handler until sent. If resend required, no second shot; if retrieve possible must be to hand. Live duck used.

UPT: Dog may leave on shot and still get high score; second shot may be used to incentivize search or if resend required. Retrieve must be within reasonable distance, generally about 1 step (3-4’); dead duck used.

WALKING AT HEEL

UT: 50-yard course, 10 sets of stakes or natural course.

UPT: 25-yard course; no stakes; around natural object if available.

REMAIN BY BLIND

UT: Must remain while handler leaves to fire shots.

UPT: Not applicable.

STEADINESS BY BLIND

UT: Distraction shots fired; must remain until sent.

UPT: Not applicable.

RETRIEVE OF DUCK

UT: Must go through decoys; retrieve to hand; duck placed at about 50 yards.

UPT: No decoys; retrieve must be within reasonable distance, generally about 1 step (3-4’); duck placed at about 40 yards.

FIELD SEARCH

UT: 30 minutes.

UPT: 25 minutes.

POINTING

No differences.

STEADINESS

UT: Must be steady through flush, wing, shot, and fall.

UPT: Steady through flush and wing.

RETRIEVE OF SHOT BIRD

UT: Retrieve to hand required.

UPT: Retrieve within reasonable distance, about 1 step (3-4’).

RETRIEVE BY DRAG

UT: 150 to 200 yards in length; retrieve to hand.

UPT: 50 yards; retrieve must be within reasonable distance, generally about 1 step (3-4’).

NOSE

No differences.

DESIRE TO WORK

No differences, however, UT dog expected to be more purposeful in work i.e., demonstrates experience.

STAMINA

Not evaluated in UPT since dog may not be fully mature or have level of experience or conditioning of a UT dog.

COOPERATION

No differences. However, UT dog should demonstrate better bond with and anticipation of handler’s desires and movements. More experience should be observable.

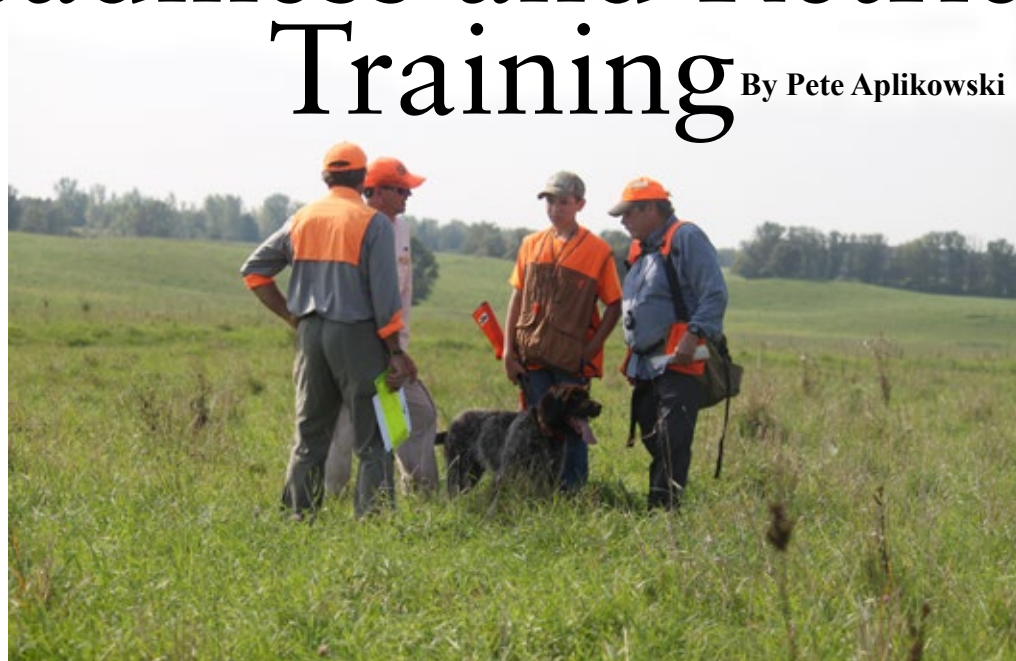
OBEDIENCE

UT: Better compliance reflecting more advanced training and better understanding of each facet of the test and hunt.

UPT: Some “puppyish” or “one off” behavior may be demonstrated indicating less maturity or experience in training and in the hunting and testing environment.

The UPT and the Practicality of Steadiness and Retrieve Training

By Pete Aplikowski



According to the NAVHDA AIMS book, The Utility Preparatory Test (UPT) is designed “to evaluate the dog midway in its training towards becoming a reliable versatile gun dog,” and the Utility Test (UT) is “designed to test a dog’s usefulness to the on-foot hunter in all phases of hunting, both before and after the shot, in field and marsh, and on different species of game.”

For an inexperienced handler, the UPT is a great introduction to the hunting team concept and the different areas of focus for the full UT. There is no age limit for a dog in the UPT, so it can also be a good way to evaluate a dog that missed running a Natural Ability test.

But what about the UPT as a measure of a dog’s usefulness to the hunter? Years ago, I had a Lab and then a Boykin spaniel. I was a novice bird-dog man, but we found, flushed, and shot birds and had fun. With some retrieving and steadiness training, it would have been a lot more fun (and much safer). There were shots taken that should not have been—low-flying birds with dogs on their tails. There was a time in Iowa that I dropped a rooster across a dredge ditch, and the dog refused to go across. It was half a mile to a bridge, and I became the

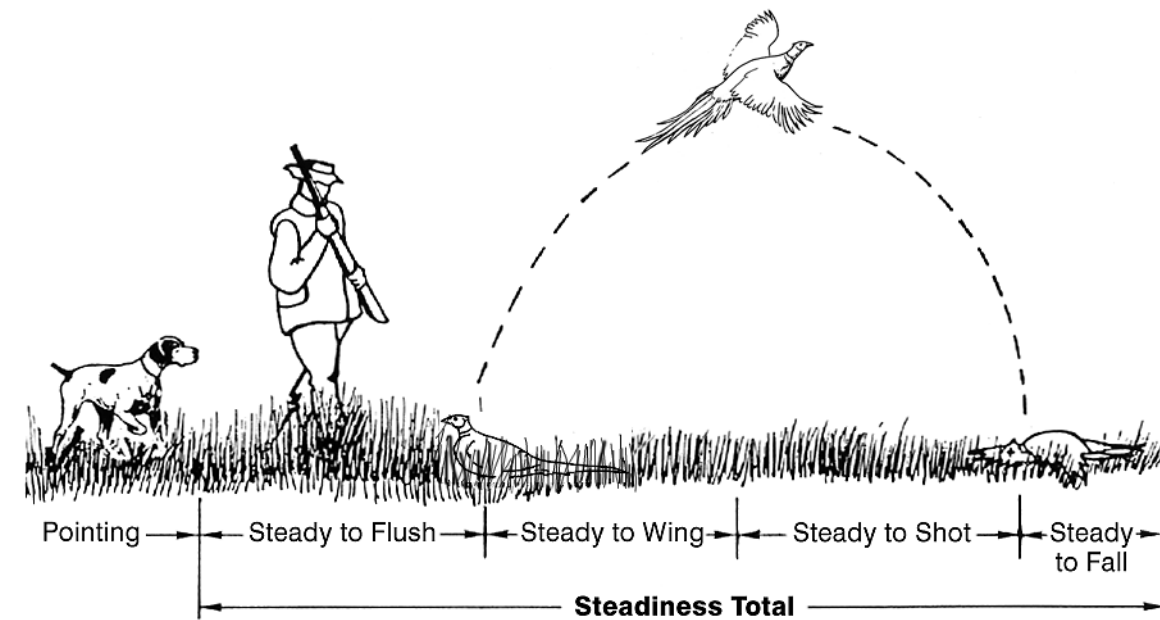
dog on that one mile retrieve. For those of you who do not hunt waterfowl and feel all the water work required of a Utility dog does not apply to your hunting style, think again. Pheasants, grouse and woodcock all live near water, and it seems almost every year one of my dogs retrieves an upland bird from water.

In the NAVHDA UPT, a dog is evaluated across many areas, but, for the purposes of the points I am trying to make with this article, let’s focus on Steadiness (in the field and at the blind) and Retrieving (land and water).

A UPT dog is evaluated only on the first two parts of the sequence—Steady to Flush, and Steady to Wing. Pay special attention to the part under Steady to Wing where it states, “ends when the gun is fired.” In the real world of hunting, a dog that is consistently Steady to Wing is a SAFE dog!

A UPT dog is also expected to retrieve a shot bird, “within a reasonable distance and easily accessible to the handler.” Dredge ditch problem solved!

A UPT dog is expected to remain by the blind in the presence of a thrown duck and a live gunshot until sent for the retrieve. This is a simpler test than the full UT sequence of the handler leaving the blind and the distraction shots, but, for most hunters, the UPT standard



would suffice and still garner compliments from your hunting buddies.

On any of the duck retrieves in the UPT, the dog is expected to just bring the duck “within reach of the handler” to receive a 4. Again, still a very useful standard for hunting without the full refinement of a finished retriever that delivers to hand as the UT requires.

As in the UT, a UPT dog must also demonstrate a water search or “duck search.” This portion of the test evaluates a dog’s desire and persistence in searching for downed or wounded game it did not see fall. On the UPT, a dead duck is used, and the dog is generally not expected to search as long or as far out as a UT dog. Still, the real-world usefulness of a dog that can perform this task (even to UPT standards) are crucial when it comes to recovering game.

Should you train and test your dog for the UPT, or skip right to the full UT? If you ask that question to a professional trainer, you might be told that that any dog that can prize in the UPT could have easily been trained a bit further to earn a prize in the UT. While this may be true, the reality is that the bulk of NAVHDA membership is made up of novice handlers and amateur trainers, many of whom are training their first dog. For these people, the UPT is a very logical stepping stone in the development of their dog and of themselves as trainers and handlers.

With proper breeding and training, all the NAVHDA breeds have the potential of becoming finished Utility dogs, and I would encourage everyone to keep training toward the UT as an end goal. Your dog deserves it. However, if you made the UPT test your final goal in NAVHDA and trained your dog to those maximum test expectations (Prize I levels), you could quit there

In NAVHDA testing, Field Steadiness is broken down into four parts as described here:

“Steady to Flush”

Judging “Steady to Flush” begins when the dog is aware of the presence of the handler. Think of “Steady to Flush” as behavior during the flushing period. The steady to flush judgment ends when the bird leaves the ground.

“Steady to Wing”

Judging “Steady to Wing” begins when the bird leaves the ground and ends when the gun is fired.

“Steady to Shot”

Judging “Steady to Shot” begins when the gun is fired and ends when the bird hits the ground.

“Steady to Fall”

Judging “Steady to Fall” begins when the bird hits the ground and ends when the dog is sent for the retrieve.

and would have a MUCH more reliable hunting dog than most bird hunters.

You also may not have to make the decision of which test to run until just prior to the test. Since the resources needed to test for UPT or UT are very similar, many chapters will allow you to switch from UPT to UT or vice versa, assuming you have already secured a spot in the running order. Check with your test secretary well in advance. Please also consult the NAVHDA AIMS book for the full details of the differences between the UPT test and the UT test.

VHD, FEBRUARY 2018

Steadiness and Introduction to Backing

By Kyle Hough

Do you wish to hunt multiple dogs in the field at one time, under control, when hunting with friends? Would you like your dog to honor other dogs' points while hunting? Then you will be interested in teaching your dog how to back.

Backing is immediate recognition by one dog that another dog is on point. The backing dog should immediately stop at a distance so it does not interfere with the pointing dog's bird contact.

The items suggested to help you train for the foundation for backing include 1: a training table, 2: bumpers, 3: a reliable e-collar or prong collar and 4: a supply of homing pigeons.

Foundation work begins by heeling. Heel your dog up and down across a training table having the dog under control at all times. Make corrections when needed so your dog will heel on command and without correction. These are short sessions, three times a day and usually about five minutes per session. When corrections are no longer needed, begin to teach the whoa command. Your dog must immediately stop upon the verbal command of whoa and should stand without moving as you walk away. After time, your dog will learn the meaning of whoa. The dog should stop immediately with no extra steps when on the table or ramps. The dog should refuse to move even when pulled or pushed.

Once this level of training has been achieved, the dog can convert from hand corrections to the e-collar or prong collar. Always start conservatively by using very low levels of stimulation with e-collar; do not make harsh corrections in initial phases if using prong collar. If the dog begins to move on whoa then apply very low stimulation on an e-collar or a quick pull on a short lead on a prong collar. Continue the pressure (the corrective action) until the dog stops moving. I need to emphasize that in either case the level of stimulation is low, not high. At this time the dog is learning that they are stimulating themselves or causing pressure to themselves by moving. Either way, the pressure can only be applied once the dog is fully aware of the command and understands what is expected from him/her. If your dog yelps, you are far too high in your levels of correction. Timing of the correction is essential. Stimulation from the e-collar is applied at a constant mode once the command of whoa is given and the dog does not stop. The pressure is immediately ceased once the dog's feet stop so they correlate the pressure with not



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following the command. Similarly, the prong collar pressure is applied the same way.

Now it's time to advance to heeling the dog up the ramp of the training table and training the foundation to "steady to flush." You will need to have objects (bumpers, gloves, etc.) hidden in your pockets or vest to throw across the table in front of the dog as distractions. Begin by heeling the dog across the training table. Immediately give the whoa command. The dog should stop without moving. While the dog is in a whoa command, throw objects across the table in front of the dog. Apply low pressure if the dog begins to move. Keep pressure until you physically pick the dog up and reposition him/her to where the initial whoa command was given. After several repetitions, you should notice your dog will soon begin stopping on his own as you toss objects. As you walk away, assuming the dog remains in the whoa position, be sure to give lots of praise. Soon, you will no longer need to make a verbal whoa and your dog will be stopping on his own to thrown objects. Again, make sure to give lots of praise at this time.

If not already outside, it's now time to take our table outside and repeat this process until your dog again

stops on his own for any thrown objects. Once that has been achieved it is time to throw homing pigeons across the table in front of your dog. At this time, you should notice you may need to increase the level of stimulation from your e-collar or add more pressure from your prong collar to make your dog stop immediately and remain steady. Continue this exercise until your dog is immediately stopping on the table for any flushed bird and remains steady when more birds are thrown in front of him when on whoa. Once your dog is steady to the flush of a bird on the table and remains steady for any additional birds thrown, you can add a blank pistol on the flush of the bird. Once again, you may find yourself increasing the amount of stimulation or pressure from either collar to make the dog steady, but this should soon stop since your dog is fully aware of how to turn off the pressure.

The foundation is now taking shape to making a dog steady to the flush, wing and shot of a bird on the table. You should expect to take a few weeks to accomplish this goal and reach this point.

VHD, JUNE 2017



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Some of the Best Utility Training and Testing Advice

By Mark Whalen

One of the best things about being a NAVHDA Judge is that we get to see a lot of dogs and handlers. We are able to observe new people who are testing for the first time, novices, seasoned trainers, pro-trainers, and everyone in between. We see some really great handling and some really poor handling. Most importantly, we get to see some truly amazing dogs and handlers.

“Hope is not a strategy.” A very wise man who helped me a great deal in my professional life would say that phrase repeatedly. I believe that same philosophy applies to training and testing as well. If you are coming to a test and hoping for the best, it may work in your favor or it may not. Chances are it will be the latter.

“Train above the test.” Another very wise man who has helped me a great deal in my dog training life says this all the time. So, what does “train above the test” really mean? In my opinion, way too many people train exactly for the test, ‘exactly’ being the key word here. The test can happen in any sequence, and the time at which each event occurs is up to the judging team and is based on weather, logistics, grounds, etc. With that said, you should be able to run every event for the test in any order. When you train, if you always do fields, drag, duck search, and always in that order, you may be in for some trouble if the judges decide to do duck searches first thing in the morning. In addition, if you are training for UT, and you always run your dog in the field for fifteen or twenty minutes, and you always give your dog two birds, what will your dog do when it runs in the test for thirty minutes or more and may find eight birds? Will it have the mental stability to handle that, or will the wheels come off? When you train duck searches, do you always use one duck, or, worse yet, dead ducks? What happens when your dog finds the duck in three minutes and needs to be re-sent? Are you 100 percent sure it will go, or are you hoping it will go? “Train above the test.” There is one thing in common with most Prize I UT dogs and Versatile Champions—they all have the mental stability to adapt, overcome and persevere. “Train above the test.”

I can’t write about test preparation without spending some time on force breaking. I see many dogs that have been properly force broken, but for every one of those

that I see, I will also see twenty that have not been properly force broken. I see a lot of dogs who stand over birds, mouth birds, drop birds, munch birds and lack any sort of finish or presentation of game. These same dogs require multiple commands, do drive by deliveries, and the handlers have to “snatch and grab” the game, kneel down or beg their dog to deliver. This all equals poor force breaking and usually equals something less than a Prize I at the end of the day. I get it...force breaking, if done properly, is difficult. It is also the most difficult thing you will ever do with your dog, and also the most important thing you will ever do for your dog. Good force breaking separates Prize I UT dogs and Versatile Champions from all the rest. People will spend thousands and thousands of dollars on a dog, birds, equipment, test fees, guns and trucks, but will not take the time to commit to force breaking. Good force breaking is the foundation for all advanced training. If you are uncomfortable with it, or don’t know how to do it, then seek out people who do. There are likely to be multiple people in your chapter who can force break. A properly force broken dog will pay dividends to you in the future, both in testing and hunting. A poorly or half-way force broken dog will haunt you and is very likely to let you down, usually at the most inopportune time.

Now for the test handling tips:

Listen

We are here to help you, and we really do want to see your dog do well. Please listen to the judges. If we ask you to do something or not to do something, we are doing that to help you. If we have to remind you multiple times it may affect your score in a negative way.

Relax

We know you’re nervous—everyone gets nervous running dogs. As judges, we have to run dogs to maintain our judge status. I can assure you that judges get nervous when they run dogs too—I know I do. Try not to let your nerves get the best of you. Your dog will pick up on your mental state, and your nervousness will transmit right down to your dog. Try as best as you can to breathe, relax, have fun and enjoy it.



Pay Attention

Pay attention to the flow of the test, and be ready when it’s your turn. Pay attention to the wind, and use it to your advantage. Pay attention to the time—look at your watch when you release your dog in the field, and use the time wisely.

Ask Questions

We are there to help you. If you’re not sure about something, please ask. We are regular people—it’s okay to talk to us.

Handle Your Dog

I can’t tell you how many people I see just stand there and let the wheels come off during the test. You are allowed to give your dog commands—however, we would like your dog to follow those commands. If you can fix something with a command, then go ahead and do it. You may take a hit for that command, or you may not. Regardless, a three in a steadiness sequence is better than a zero. Too many times I hear from handlers that someone in the parking lot told them they can’t talk to their dog. You can talk to your dog during a test. A good rule of thumb is to give commands and talk to your dog only when the dog needs it, and be silent and let the dog work if it doesn’t need it.

Water

Bring water to the field with you regardless of the outside temperate. For UT dogs, you really should not be putting your hands on the dogs while testing for any reason other than praise or to give them water. I give my dog water in the field after every retrieve. This gives me the opportunity to put my hands on the dog, calm him down, and talk to him quietly a little bit.

Handle Your Gunners

There are some really outstanding gunners out there that will be in perfect position every time without the handler saying anything. For gunners who aren’t that experienced, it’s the handlers’ job to let them know which way they plan to flush the bird and to quickly position them for a clean, safe shot.

History

Please know that we only evaluate your dog for a very short period of time on any given test day. We generally don’t know the history of your dog and what it usually does or does not do. We evaluate your dog only on what we see and what actually happens during each event.

Have Fun

Have fun and enjoy your testing experience!

VHD, JULY 2016

Retrieve by Drag

By Tim Otto

Everyone knows that “Use of Nose” is a prominent category on the scorecard for every NAVHDA test, having the highest Index Number (multiplier) of 6. Many people are surprised to learn, however, that “Use of Nose” is not scored in the Retrieve by Drag portion of the Utility Test. Why? You’ve got one judge, and maybe an apprentice judge, with big smelly boots (sorry!) dragging a fat, dead duck, pheasant, or piece of furred game, laying what many people refer to as a “highway of scent” out to where the game is ultimately placed. Thus, the drag is not a sensitive test of Nose—any reasonably well-bred dog ought to have no difficulty scenting the drag. Problems with Nose are much more likely to be apparent in more sensitive situations, like scenting a small bird in a large field either during a search or on a retrieve where the bird went down in cover, or when following the scent of a duck on water. Basically, from a Nose perspective, the drag is among the easiest things any of our dogs will ever have to do.

If the Retrieve by Drag doesn’t test nose, what does it test? If you take a close look at the Utility scorecard, you see there’s only three places judges can put a score: Desire, Cooperation, and Obedience. We all know the old adage, “Desire takes your dog out, Cooperation is your dog picking up the game and turning around to come back, and Obedience is the finished delivery.” So, basically it’s nothing more than a long retrieve. With this in mind, the surefire way to be successful in the Retrieve by Drag is to have a *very* strong foundation in retrieve training. You may assume that this is not a whole lot different than the elements in Retrieve of Shot Bird in the Field sequence, and you’d be mostly right, but the Retrieve by Drag adds a couple of important extra elements over and above the Retrieve of Shot Bird. The two main differences are pretty obvious: in the Drag,

the game is placed out of sight of the handler and is much farther away than any shot bird in the field sequence. One important thing that the Retrieve by Drag tests is what your dog will do when he/she knows you can’t see what’s going on. And what can that be? Burying it, peeing on it, playing with it, or willfully leaving or mutilating it. This will obviously hurt your score. Equally, often the dog may stop to pee or “reposition” the game 15 yards from the handler. Don’t fool yourself—the dog picked that game up and carried it back, what, 120 yards, and *now* it has to reposition it? Probably not. And did your dog really need to pee 10 yards away? If so, that was a handler error—always get your dog to empty its bladder just before the drag. Most likely, under either scenario, your dog is telling you one thing: it doesn’t really want to come deliver that bird just now, thank you. As you train, do not let your dog get away with these things—ever.

Another important factor to remember is that, at the end of the drag, one or two people are hiding behind a tree or in some bushes, and, occasionally, the fast moving dog will pass the game and see those people. You have to train for this so your dog doesn’t get spooked. I always urge people to have their first drag quite short, let the dog watch the person dragging the game, and have that person stand 15-20 yards past the drop point. As you progress in your training toward the “real” drag (100-200 yds), occasionally have your helper lean against a tree or other-

wise be visible at the end of the drag. Whether visible or not, this helper should *never* scold, yell at, or surprise your dog for misbehaving—but it *is* helpful if you both have a two-way radio. This way your helper can tell you quietly if your dog is misbehaving and you can get in a correction by yelling “NO, FETCH” and using your e-collar if necessary.

VHD, MARCH 2017



A Simplified Approach to HEELING

By Jeff Ebert

Heeling is one of the easier obedience lessons to teach your dog, but many dog owners seem to struggle with this concept. I have witnessed perhaps dozens of schemes to get a dog to heel, including pinch collars, funny looking leads, and some harnesses that attempt to physically distort the dog into submission. Many of the problems stem from the dog’s drive and desire to get out and just have fun. After all, heeling means we are going for a walk right? Other problems can arise from the lack of good communication between handler and dog. When we issue the “Heel” command, what is the expected behavior?

As with anything we teach our dogs, breaking skills down to the most basic level often leads to the quickest success. If we want to teach a dog to be steady to wing, shot and fall, it is not a good idea to teach all these skills all at once. There are too many variables. Instead, we would teach the dog to be steady on the sight of a bird, and then steady to the flush. We would follow this by teaching steady to the gun, and then finally the fall of the bird. So, why is it that we try to teach heel by dragging a dog on a lead to our side and immediately try to get it to follow us as we go on walkabout? Once again, too many variables—it takes the dog a little longer to realize that what we mean is to follow us at our side. This can be increasingly difficult if your dog likes to lead or pull.

It is important to realize that obedience is the foundation that we build all of our training on, and compliance without submission is our goal. So, if you are struggling with this obedience skill, or if you have not mastered it by the time your dog is ready for bird training, consider this simplified approach to heeling. Remember that NAVHDA recognizes heeling as simply an obedience skill—it is not scored in any category except obedience. It is your dog’s willingness to respond to command. Without this basic skill, all the rest of your training breaks down.

By modifying the heeling lesson only slightly, this approach will attempt to address your dog’s desire to get out and go, and it will break the lesson down to its most basic level so that communication between dog and handler is successful.

To begin, stand in a position as if you are ready to start walking. With your dog on lead, issue a heel command and bring the dog to your side in heeling position. Do not walk! Praise your dog for a correct response and position. Your dog should be standing facing forward with its head aligned to your knee. Repeat this process without moving. Add in to your training a hand signal for heeling such as a tap on your knee. Repeat this training process for several

short periods throughout the day until your dog reliably comes to your side in heel position without you moving. You can extend this by increasing the lead length, changing your stance and changing your position. Do not attempt to walk the dog until you can reliably get the dog to come to your side on command with “Heel.” You are now ready for the walk. Begin with just a few straight steps. If your dog does not follow, repeat the command and assist it in coming back to the heel position with a snap of the leash. Continue by extending your straight line walk and getting your dog to follow in that position. If your dog begins to lead, stop and command heel. Use leash corrections to get the dog to return to your side.

When this works reliably, you are ready for a couple of turns. Do not make the mistake that most new handlers make and turn away from your dog. In the beginning, you want to turn into the dog. Make the dog move out of your way and maintain visible contact with your knee. Soon you will see that your dog watches for your turn. Now you are ready to turn away from your dog. Again, encourage your dog to the heel position with leash corrections. *The leash should never be tight*—it is a correction tool and not a restraint. The rest is repetition. You will actually find it will not take long for your dog to reliably heel on command. Actual results may vary. You can increase the challenge for your dog by changing pace and adding obstacles like walking on heel through the woods. It is very important to remember that, at first, the duration of the heel should be kept short. Do not let your dog become bored with the lesson. Too many people place their dog on heel and go for a half mile walk around the block. The dog will always lose interest. *Remember*, “Heel” is a command. With all commands, there *must* be a release. Without the release, your dog will start to test how long is “long enough.” This is a breakdown in obedience. The heel, like all commands, must be maintained until the dog is commanded with a release. This is another lesson and is called “Consistency.”

Why is this approach different in the dog’s eyes? Well, perhaps the biggest reason is that you are teaching your dog that “Heel” means to come to your side, and *not* that we are going for a walk. Perhaps equally important, is that you can successfully communicate to your dog that there is only a single action—coming to your side in heel position—that will result in praise and reward. In addition, the dog will not become distracted by the sights and smells of every little thing you walk by. Give it a try!

VHD, APRIL 2016

Training for the Duck Search

By Tom Swezey

There are a number of approaches to train a dog to do a successful NAVHDA Utility duck search. No one method works with every dog. Here are some methods I have found that have shown good results.

Before starting duck search training, I highly recommend going through retrieve training. Having gone through retrieve training assumes the dog reliably, and without fail, retrieves dead and live ducks on land at distances out to 100+ yards. For me, retrieve training is the foundation for duck search training. Proper retrieve training also affords you the tools necessary to reinforce the duck search on days when the dog may decide to quit early or not search at all. Without the tools to make a correction when needed, you are counting on a lot of luck. I have had dogs that would consistently do a “4” duck search every time without any issues, but I have also worked with many more dogs that required ‘work’ before their duck search was consistently good.

Before going to the water with a duck, I do a considerable amount of ‘land duck searches.’ Starting duck search training on land is basically an extension of the retrieve training. The dead of winter is a great time to start your duck search training—after hunting season, and before the ice is off the water in early spring. I start by shooting flyers on land at distances out to 100+ yards. At first the dog sees the duck fall. I incrementally progress to the point where the dog only hears the shot before being sent to find ducks in a ‘salted’ field. As the dog progresses, I eliminate the gun shot altogether. When I’m confident the dog knows the job, ‘search and find the duck,’ I will incrementally increase the distance the dog will need to search before finding a duck. The same issues we see at the water—quitting early, not expanding, or not searching at all—still have the potential of showing up on land. I find it easier and quicker to address each problem on land vs. in the water. Also, the winter dead time can be put to good use and keep you from becoming a coach potato.

The exercise of finding and retrieving ducks on land has not affected the pointing of game birds or even pigeons in release traps. I have used the same field to do both duck searches and planted birds for steadiness training on the same day with no problem making the switch from water fowl to upland training.

When spring arrives and duck search training moves to the water, the transition from land to water can go

very quickly. I start the same way I did on land and go through the same incremental progression. After establishing a solid duck search on land, I find the duck search on water progresses very quickly without many issues popping up. The expectation was established on land and carried forward to the water.

When transitioning to the water, there are a few things that change. I want the dog to always go straight into the water and cross whatever body of water I send him to. I never let them run the near shorebank. The ducks are always going to be planted closer to the far shoreline in cover. At first, they will be straight across and incrementally spread out in various places farther away from the starting point. I shackle the ducks’ legs and remove the flight feathers from one wing. That way when the dog gets close to the duck, the duck can try to paddle away with its wings. This kicks in the dogs’ prey drive and makes it very exciting for them. Having the duck’s legs shackled limits the distance a duck can dive and a persistent dog will eventually catch the duck.

To help the dogs learn to expand their search, I may use a large, duck-size, remote release trap with a duck quack incorporated into the receiver. If the dog looks like it may not expand enough to find the duck, I may use the duck quack to get their attention. When the dog gets within range of the trap I will release the duck from the trap.

No matter what, I will make sure the dog is always successful finding a duck. I time the duck search, and if the dog has searched diligently for over ten to fifteen minutes and not found a duck, I will make sure they find a duck to be successful. I always have a kayak at the starting point and will slip into the water and set a duck upwind of the dog if I need to, to make them successful then quickly return to the starting point to receive the finished retrieve.

The expectation set on land and carried forward to the water is: search for the duck and don’t come back unless you have a duck or unless I call you off, which is extremely infrequent.

Again, this is just one approach. My advice has always been listen to the people that are successful in training, but you are the final filter to see what is going to work for you and your dog.

VHD, OCTOBER 2016

Training for the Duck Search

By Tom Swezey

Some Finer Points

After reading Tom Swezey’s duck search advice in the October 2016 VHD, NAVHDA member and judge Rich Jarosinski asked Tom to expand on some of the finer points. We share their conversation in this article.

Do you use different commands for a straight retrieve vs. the duck search? If so, what are the reasons?

Personally, I use the same ‘Fetch’ command for both a straight retrieve and a duck search. Dogs read our body language. I believe they know what the job is by the way we approach it. I start the duck search the same way every time I send them. It may be in a different location, but my approach to the water, how I set them up, and how I send them is the same every time. Sure, I may shoot the shotgun once in awhile but they know the job by repetition. With that said, I know many trainers that will use ‘back’ on the blind retrieve and maybe ‘find it’ for the duck search. I believe the key is your body language in communicating with out dogs.

Do you use dead ducks for all “land” work and then move to live ducks with water work?

I use bumpers, dead ducks and live ducks on land and water. The goal is an expanded search with no quitting. I approach all my training in increments of increased difficulty: steadiness, retrieving and duck search training all use increments of difficulty.

Do you do land work and the water work at different locations during the training process?

I use different locations for both land and water work. I think its very important to use multiple locations for all aspects of training. I have a 30 acre field where I start my training, but the dogs become conditioned to my field. You need to move locations for both field and water work to ensure the dogs are not just conditioned to certain locations. A key point when moving to new locations during your training is to back up from the level of difficulty you used in your previous location. Start at a level of difficulty where your confidence level is near 100%. They will do the job successfully, then you increase the difficulty.

What distances do you start out with for searching when starting the land work?

The following advice assumes you have completed your retrieve training, and your dog will retrieve dead or live ducks to hand. When I start the land duck search, I want it to be fun and exciting. There will be plenty of time to increase the difficulty. I use a live flightless duck to start with. I’ll put the dog on a whoa, walk out in the field 30 or so yards and set the duck on the ground. When I return to the dog, I stand by his side for 20 seconds so the dog learns to wait for the command. Then I send the dog. I like training in sets of three: puppy pheasant tracks, utility duck drags, steadiness sequences, duck searches etc., all revolve around doing sets of three.

Do you use regular duck hunting as a training exercise to supplement this other training work?

Any time you can take your dog hunting, go and have fun. The more exposure to hunting the better. Some of my first ‘duck searches’ have been while pheasant hunting.

This has always been the toughest event for my Brittanies. I am always interested in new duck search training methods.

The NAVHDA Utility duck search can be a challenge for any breed. My first question to anyone having trouble with the duck search is always, “Tell me how you do your retrieve training.” As I said in the first paragraph of my last article, finished retrieve training is the foundation for developing a solid, reliable duck search. This showed up in spades while I was working with an Irish Setter show champion to do a Utility duck search.

Here is some advice for anyone having trouble with their training: listen to the people that have ‘walked the walk.’ I try to learn from the best trainers I know. It has taken me many years of listening and trying to become somewhat proficient. I know who the best trainers are, and I still enjoy learning from them. You are the final filter to see what will work in communicating with your dog.

VHD, JANUARY 2017

The Utility Blind Sequence

By Tim Otto

What I refer to here as the “Blind Sequence” is actually composed of four separate segments, each of which is scored independently. These are, in order, Heeling, Remaining by the Blind, Steadiness at the Blind, and Retrieve of Duck. Before you start the sequence, the judges will sometimes ask whether you want your instructions all at once or rather have them described individually at the beginning of each separate segment of the sequence. Under these conditions, my own preference is to take them all at once so that I can execute the entire sequence without stopping, but during training you should always practice stopping between each segment and mimic receiving instructions so that, if that happens in a test, it won’t be the first time! One additional training tip: *you should always train for the Blind Sequence with plenty of other people around to mimic the conditions of the test* (three judges, possibly two apprentices, and usually a small gallery) and to provide distractions for your dog. Finally, many people wait to train for the Blind Sequence until after they have a rock-solid duck search. Training for them simultaneously can cause confusion for some dogs and negatively impact duck search training.

The heeling course is composed of 10 pairs of gates, which will form a heeling course roughly three feet wide and approximately 50 yards long, with a curve or bend in the course, and ending at a blind at the water’s edge. Of course, there are sometimes limitations on the heeling course imposed by the landscape, so the suggested 50-yard length of the course is more of a guideline than an absolute requirement. You will be given a break-open 12g shotgun which you will carry with you through the heeling course. *The scoring for heeling begins when the handler gives his/her first command*, whether that is a verbal “heel”, a tug on the leash, a slap on thigh, or some other command the handler chooses; *the scoring ends not at the last gate, but when the handler/dog reaches the blind at the edge of the water*. Throughout the heeling course, judges will be looking for a loose lead – many experienced handlers are careful to *make sure that there is an obvious “J” in the lead prior to starting the course*, that is, that the lead hangs in such a way that the bottom part of the “J” in the lead hangs below the dog’s collar. Starting off with a tight lead will accentuate even the most minor problems. Judges will be watching the dog closely to determine whether it is tugging on the lead or lurching ahead of the handler. Corrections by the handler, ranging from jerking on the

lead, obvious scuffing of the feet, or a verbal command can lower the heeling score. Heeling is one of the absolutely basic and necessary things our dogs will ever do, so the best way to do well in this portion of the test is simple: teach your dog to heel well with distractions around. *The value of great heeling extends well beyond the score you get in your Utility test!*

At the end of the heeling course, you will begin the “Remain by Blind” component of the sequence, and you will be asked to first position your dog either inside or next to the blind and remove the lead; it doesn’t matter whether you have your dog sit, stand, or lie down, and you can leave your lead or some other item with, but not touching, the dog. The judges will then ask you to take your shotgun and two blank “popper” loads and position yourself in a location they indicate that will be out of sight of your dog. When properly positioned, you will shoot two rounds approximately 10 seconds apart, then return to your dog. A training tip that is absolutely key – although in the test itself you will be asked to fire twice, *during training you should always mix this up, sometimes firing once, sometimes five times, sometimes not at all*. If you only fire two shots every time you train, your dog will learn pretty quickly that it’s over at two shots, which can lead to problems with breaking. *You should also vary where you go to fire your shots during training* – sometimes to the left, sometimes to the right, sometimes behind the dog. Just because you go to a particular place during training on your home grounds doesn’t necessarily mean that’s where the judges will ask you to go on test day, and you and your dog need to be ready for anything. It’s important to note too that whining (I’m referring to the dog here, but I imagine it would apply to the handler as well!) or barking during this phase will almost certainly lower your score; the logic here is that if the dog is vocalizing in a duck hunting situation, that would likely result in your ducks flaring on you. After firing your two shots, return to your dog calmly. Throughout this sequence, your dog is expected to remain in the position you left him - sitting, standing, or lying down in or next to the blind – for a maximum score of 4. If the dog takes a step or two in any direction, the dog can receive a Prize I score (3) but not a 4. Abandoning the blind, for example entering the water or taking a number of steps toward the handler, is not a good thing and if severe enough could cost you a prize completely. *You should always train with someone you trust and who knows your*

dog; ask him/her to stand about 15 feet behind your dog and give them your e-collar transmitter or make verbal corrections should the dog misbehave while you can’t see him.

The “Steadiness by Blind” segment immediately follows Remain by Blind. If you left your dog in the blind during Remain by Blind you will need to reposition your dog so that it is standing or sitting next to the blind facing the water; you can also reposition him if you left him outside the blind if you choose. Once your dog is positioned next to the blind and you are in the blind, load a popper into your gun and indicate to the judges that you are ready. At this point a distraction gunner positioned well to the left or right of the blind will fire a shot, and you will fire soon thereafter. After you are reloaded, the distraction gunner will fire yet another shot, and just after this the judges will indicate that a dead duck be launched so that it lands approximately 50 yards away, preferably in open water. You fire your final shot while the duck is in the air to mimic actually shooting a duck. Your dog is expected to remain steady without commands until released for the retrieve; there should be a noticeable pause between when the duck lands and when you send the dog. As with the Remain by Blind component, *during training you should always vary the number and sequence of shots fired during the Steadiness by Blind segment. You should also plan on launching two or three ducks once in a while during training. Keep it interesting*. This is perhaps even more important than during training for Remain by Blind because if you always fire a total of four shots while training, your dog will very quickly learn that the duck always appears after the third shot, which dramatically increases the chances that it will break after the third shot in anticipation of the duck. As an extreme example of the “mix it up” philosophy, I know one very well-respected trainer whose dogs never hear the four shots used during testing until the day of the test itself.

Judgment for the “Retrieve of Duck” component begins when you give your fetch command. Your dog is expected to swim directly to the duck, pick it up, and return to you by land or water and complete the finished retrieve. More specifically, upon return your dog “should sit or stand quietly close to the handler until commanded to release the duck to hand. Anticipating this command or dropping the game must be penalized.” I’ve copied this directly from the NAVH-DA Aims manual because it’s the best, most succinct



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description of a finished retrieve as I’ve seen. “Fly-by” retrieves where the dog is trotting past the handler, requiring to handler to reach out and snatch the duck as the dogs passes by will be penalized, as will dropping the duck on the way, playing with the duck, etc. Here’s a testing tip – *if your dog meets the conditions for a finished retrieve, that is, standing or sitting quietly, don’t hesitate to give your “out” command and get that duck*. All too often I’ve seen handlers waiting and waiting for... What? I don’t know.

Assuming you’ve read this far, it almost certainly took you longer than actually executing the Blind Sequence itself (although during the test it can sometimes seem like a very long time). The bottom line here is that this sequence is actually composed of four independent segments scored individually. Train with people around and mix it up. Over-training this segment of the Utility test can get boring for both you and the dog, particularly if it’s the same every time. Keep it fun and interesting, and don’t overdo it.

VHD, JULY 2018

Teaching Backing

By Kyle Hough

Before we have your dog backing, we first must make him steady to flush, wing and shot, particularly to birds that wild flush – as we'll see later in this article, consistently stopping to a flush is the backbone to training backing.

Currently, you have the dog consistently stopping to the flush and shot of a pigeon flushed in front of the dog while on the training table and on the ground. Now it's time to take the dog to the field. You will be using a number of homing pigeons securely placed in bird bags. During this sequence, be prepared to make corrections as needed. If you are using the e-collar to stop your dog by using steady stimulation, a lead is not necessary. If you're using the prong collar, a lead must be worn on the dog to make a correction. It is helpful to have a friend throw pigeons near your dog so that you can make timely corrections. If your dog is yelping from the corrections made with the e-collar, you are using too high a level of stimulation and must back down on your level. Do not over stimulate.

While your dog is running in the field, turn the dog using a whistle. Set the transmitter on your e-collar to the level that stopped your dog while on the table. As your dog is near (only a few yards away), have your friend throw a pigeon toward your dog's location. If your dog does not immediately stop to the flush, use steady stimulation with the e-collar until the dog stops (your dog will know how to turn off the stimulation from the initial foundation work you did on the training table). If your dog doesn't stop after steady stimulation, the next time use a slightly higher level of steady stimulation until the dog stops... stimulate for any movement once dog recognizes the flush, and stop the stimulation immediately when the dog stops moving. A few good corrections and your dog will soon skid to a stop on the flush of birds. Timing is the key.

If you are using the prong collar and check cord, this will be a bit more difficult. You would have to apply pressure from the cord via the prong collar on the flush, and obviously the pressure would stop once the dog stops to the flush.

Once your dog is stopping to wild flushes, reinforce a verbal "whoa" and tell him "good dog." While your dog is on whoa, kick around the grass near your dog and flush additional birds by nonchalantly dropping them from the bird bag. Now is the time to add the

shot. Repeat the sequence until your dog is completely steady without movement. Continue with this training until you obtain consistency; that is, the dog stops and is steady to flush and shot, even with additional birds thrown at him from your bird bag.

As we've said, before we have your dog backing, we first must make him fully steady to the flush, wing and shot. Now, take four electronic traps with homing pigeons in each trap and place them in your field. Carry along two bird bags, one with homing pigeons and another with birds that can be shot. Having a friend along to help shoot while you steady your dog with the e-collar or prong collar is very helpful. Allow your dog to search and point one of the traps with the homing pigeon. While your dog is on point, walk towards your dog from a sideways approach (never walk up behind your dog), add a verbal whoa and drop an additional homing pigeon from your bird bag. Release the trap and fire a shot. Be prepared to make any corrections needed until your dog is completely steady. Once the dog is completely steady, take a bird to be shot from your other bag and flush it while your friend shoots it. Expect to make a correction here. You may need to slightly increase your level of stimulation. Remember to watch your dog for any corrections; do not watch the bird being shot. If your dog moves, simply pick him up and put him back. Flush another bird and have your friend shoot it. When your dog is finally steady, allow him to retrieve. Now move on to the second trap. Your dog will soon learn that being steady pays off and only when the dog is steady will he be able to retrieve. If you follow the training steps in sequence, you will find yourself making very little, if any, corrections by the fourth trap. Repeat this exercise until your dog is steady...now it's time to teach him backing.

You will need a friend with a steady dog, a helper to shoot birds and your traps and birds in bags. Place the four electronic traps with homing pigeons in each trap in your training field. Have your friend release his dog first and have him direct his dog toward the first trap while you start in a different direction. Once your friend's dog is on point, hunt your dog toward his location while trying to come in sideways, giving your dog a good look at the pointing dog. At the time your dog first looks at the pointing dog, immediately release the trap, and the homing pigeon will fly up in front of the pointing dog. Assuming you've followed the previous steps and your dog is



stopping to wild flushed, your dog will stop immediately to the flush of the bird from the trap based on all of his foundation work. Now, walk next to your dog and tell him good dog while giving him a verbal whoa. Have your friend flush a bird from his bag in front of the pointing dog and shoot it. Make any steady corrections if needed here. Once your dog is steady, have your friend flush a second bird from his bag in front of the pointing dog and have it shot. Allow your dog the first retrieve while the pointing dog honors. Then allow the pointing dog a retrieve while your dog honors. The important thing here is to let the flushed pigeon from the trap stop your dog, and *do not* stimulate your dog to make him stop. You may use stimulation once your dog has already stopped to the flush to reinforce any steadiness corrections if needed.

Move on to the next trap. Use above methods but this time let the pointing dog retrieve first, and then have your dog retrieve second. Soon your dog will be looking for the other dog in the field, and, when he sees him on point, he will immediately back on his own. Once your dog is backing immediately on his own, it's now no longer necessary to pop the trap and release the pigeon to stop him. You can now flush a bird from a bag in front of the pointing dog and shoot it. Release the trap while shooting into the air as a miss, and then release another bird from the bag in front of the pointing dog and shoot it. By doing this, you are reminding your dog that birds are sometimes missed, while helping his ability to mark birds previously shot.

Continue this exercise by using traps until your dog is a consistent backing dog that is steady as he honors. When this is achieved, it's now time to allow both dogs to run freely and hunt equally for the point while the other backs and honors. As your training continues and your dog becomes proficient with his backing and honoring, you may begin to wean away his retrieves for backing; you will need to assess this based on your dog's willingness to back. Dogs differ, and some will require more retrieves in the beginning stages to keep them intense about backing, while other dogs may not need as many retrieves to keep them intense. You will find that some dogs will back naturally, some will back after only one lesson, and others may need several lessons until backing is achieved. It is important to occasionally shoot multiple birds over a single point and give both dogs retrieves to keep their backing intense and honest.

Once your dog is becoming proficient in backing, allow your dog the chance to hunt on his own. Taking your dog hunting without another dog will help limit the amount of stress that sometimes is generated by dogs competing against one another. Finally, I suggest taking your dog on a fall hunting trip with other dogs that have been trained to back. Watch how flushing wild birds enhances backing skills. Hopefully it will allow for a few more birds in your bag. Best of luck!

VHD, JULY 2017

Understanding How We Use the Principles of Pavlovian and Skinnerian Conditioning to Modify Behavior in Our Dogs

By Jason Carter & Matt McKenney

As a teacher, sitting through a day-long professional development workshop has never been something I look forward to, but this workshop was different and struck a chord unlike most. Although the training focused on behavior management in the classroom, I found myself relating most of the theories and concepts we discussed back to my dog training. I immediately thought of how Bodo Winterhelt, a co-founder of NAVHDA, contacted Ed Bailey many years ago to write the “Green Book” and put the “why” behind the “how” in the NAVHDA system. I realized that the guiding principles underlying most training systems were ultimately very similar, focusing on “behavior management” in our dogs. With this in mind, I contacted my friend and Yankee Chapter member Matt McKenney, a board certified Behavior Analyst who has worked in the field of Applied Behavioral Analysis in education. I thought he might help describe the science behind behavior management in general. It is our hope to help you identify why some training methods work well and to help you avoid some of the common pitfalls we frequently find ourselves in.

Lessons from Drooling Dogs and Pigeon Boxes

As it turns out, most of the techniques we use in dog training have a history in science and have been strongly influenced by the world-renowned scientists Ivan Pavlov and B.F. Skinner. Along with the work of many others, they laid the groundwork for modern day behavioral science.

Before we go any further, let’s make sure everyone has a basic understanding of Pavlovian (also known as “classical”) and Skinnerian (also known as “operant”) conditioning. Because Pavlov came first, we’ll start with Classical Conditioning. Probably everybody knows about “Pavlov’s dog,” who learned to salivate in response to a bell. In short, the process that Pavlov observed was that some responses occur naturally in a hard-wired, reflexive way, and that those responses can

be “conditioned” to occur in response to novel stimuli. In this example, Pavlov noted that putting food on a dog’s tongue made it salivate reflexively – the dog didn’t have to learn this; it just happened naturally. On the other hand, simply ringing a bell did not make the dog salivate naturally. He then rang the bell and immediately put food on the tongue several times, and found that when he later just rang the bell in the absence of food the dog salivated—the dog **LEARNED** the association between the bell and the food, and now the dog salivated to a bell when it never did before. Over time the process of presenting the bell and food simultaneously resulted in a conditioned response from the dog, drooling. Like you, I see this nearly every day when I open the door to the food stash and the feed pans make noise – the dogs drool all over the floor!

B.F. Skinner’s work on Operant Conditioning was strongly influenced by Pavlov’s, and he is well known for his work in the Experimental Analysis of Behavior. Using pigeons, rats, and other animals, Skinner examined the process of Antecedent (what comes first), Behavior (the desired response), and Consequence (the strengthening or weakening of the response over time). This process is known as the ABC’s of behavior, or the three term contingency. Antecedents are stimuli and conditions that evoke any given Behavior to occur, and Consequences are the stimuli that immediately follow the behavior. It is the Consequences that then serve to increase (reinforce) or decrease (punish) the frequency of the behavior in the future. A common example of the Operant Conditioning is training your dog to sit. You start by getting your dog’s attention and saying “sit” (the antecedent). You physically put your dog in the ‘sit’ position (the desired behavior), and then you immediately give the dog a treat (the consequence). Over a number of training trials, you teach your dog to sit effectively without having to put your hands on him/her.

Good teaching effectively uses both Pavlovian and Operant Conditioning. While training your dog, awareness of



these processes will only serve to enhance your ability to train more effectively and efficiently.

As an illustration of how we use these two learning methods, let’s take a look at how we whistle-train dogs to recall or come. Please allow me to take some liberties as I explain this. While leash training, you may initially be using a long lead to teach your dog to return when asked. You command your dog to sit and he does. You walk to the end of the 15-foot lead and say, “come.” Using the principles of operant conditioning and reinforcement, your dog learns that when you say come, he is to go to your side and get reinforced with a “good boy,” a pat on the head, and/or a treat. Off-leash training commences once this is firmly established. Later in your training sequence, you teach the dog to come to the whistle using Pavlovian conditioning. In other words, you pair the new stimulus—the whistle—with a stimulus that means something—the “come” command. The first trial of teaching your dog to come when you blow the whistle should be saying, “come” and then immediately blowing the whistle. With repeated exposure to this process you then begin to blow the whistle first, then say, “come.” When he does, give him a good strong Skinnerian “GOOD BOY!” or a treat to reinforce the behavior. Once your dog

is consistently performing, you can start to fade the verbal command, and only use the whistle. When your dog reliably comes to your side with only the whistle command, you have effectively used Operant and Classical Conditioning in your training sequences.

Combining both Classical and Operant conditioning principles is an effective way to teach your dog pretty much anything, including whoa, stay, fetch, kennel, and back.

Make Your Commands Count!

How many times have you seen someone using their whistle, or yelling “WHOA” or “COME” while their dog pays no attention? This almost always reflects inadequate foundation training, and using those commands without consequence is setting their dog back in its training. Interestingly, both Pavlov and Skinner demonstrated that giving commands (for example a whistle or a verbal “come” or “whoa” command) that have no consequences actually slow down later learning. Let’s imagine Pavlov’s dog heard a bell over and over without the presentation of food, and later on he paired presentations of the bell and food—it turns out learning to salivate to that bell takes **LONGER** if he had heard the bell previously. Why? Because the dog initially learned that the bell was meaningless. Later on the dog actually had to learn two things—the bell is no longer irrelevant **AND** the bell predicts food. Similarly, in Operant conditioning, giving any command without the subsequent behavior and reinforcement will slow down later learning of that command. Like the bell, the dog has learned that “come” has no meaning or consequence, and later has to learn **TWO** things—“come” is no longer irrelevant **AND** if I “come” I’ll get something reinforcing like a treat or a “good boy.” The bottom line: Don’t use commands over and over without the behavior and subsequent reinforcement—you’re only making it harder for the dog to learn that command in the future.

One last point here—many of you may be thinking, “I’d just use my e-collar to make the dog come or whoa.” This is an effective means of training only after the dog knows the meaning of the command! You should never stimulate a dog with an e-collar if he doesn’t know what the command means first. The appropriate use of e-collars in training is well beyond the scope of the present article, but suffice it to say that any good training program is built on a foundation of Pavlovian and Operant conditioning principles that use positive reinforcement, and the e-collar is used effectively only after the dog knows the commands.

VHD, APRIL 2018

Handling in the Field

By Tim Otto

Knowing when you should give your dog commands in the field during testing can be confusing. Typically, whether it's an NA, UPT, or UT test, before going out in the field the judge handling you and your dog will often tell you something like this: "Handle your dog as you normally would during training or hunting..." And this is exactly what you should do. Often, though, at some point one of the judges may ask you to call your dog around when you might not have otherwise.

Why might the judges ask you to call your dog around? There are many reasons why, but, in my experience, one of the most common reasons is to get your dog out of potential trouble. For example, late in

the day, the previously flushed but unshot birds often congregate in woods adjacent to the field where you're testing; if judges see your dog going into an area they know is full of birds running in the open, they may tell you to call your dog out of there because, really, nothing good can happen in that situation. Remember, the judges are truly there to help you. Another reason judges may ask you to call your dog is to get it back into the relevant area. As described in the Search portion of the NAVHDA: *Aims, Program, Test Rules* booklet, "the dog should conduct its search at a practical distance from the gun" and "... the uncontrolled dog running the far horizons is of little use to the on-foot hunter." If the judges sense that your dog may be out of practical range, they will likely ask you to call him back. Yet another reason they may ask you to call your dog is to get a sense of whether your dog is cooperative or, in the case of the UPT or UT test, obedient (obedience is not scored in the NA test). Handlers and their dogs should display a sense of teamwork, particularly in the UPT and UT tests; a dog that won't heed a handler's call to come around will probably not be getting maximum scores in cooperation or obedience. Still another reason a judge may ask you to call your dog around when you might not normally is to get it on a bird in a known location. Perhaps they are on the fence about your pointing score, or steadiness or retrieving in UPT and UT, and need to see another bird contact to settle the issue.

Equally often, judges might ask you to **not** give your dog verbal commands when you might normally. Again, there are way too many reasons why this might be the case to describe here, but always when this happens, they are trying to help you and your dog in some way. Perhaps they want to see a little more



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independence and willingness to search. Maybe you are either knowingly or unknowingly "whoa-ing" your dog when you see it getting birdy. If this happens, judges will almost certainly ask you not to do that on subsequent bird contacts, because a dog on "whoa" is not pointing. Again, quoting from the Aims manual, "When game is located the dog must establish point naturally. The handler is strictly prohibited from giving any commands or gestures which may induce the dog to point." With respect to the "whoa" command, many of us use it during training after the dog has gone on point as we are moving in to flush the bird, and then instinctively use it at that time during testing. Here is another case where judges may ask you to keep quiet so that they can fully judge steadiness. The whoa command in this circumstance should definitely be used if you absolutely need it to stop the dog from breaking, but otherwise try and resist the temptation. Another reason you might be asked to keep quiet is to assess cooperation or obedience – does the dog pay attention to where you are and move with you, or is it out self-hunting? A dog that doesn't care where his or her handler is and is out hunting for itself alone is not a

cooperative dog, and his or her scores will probably reflect that.

I can't tell you the number of times I've seen or heard judges ask a handler to call their dog around and the handler stays quiet. Sometimes it's nerves – handlers often don't hear too well when they're running dogs (I know I don't!). A number of handlers, though, have told me and others that they've heard that verbally communicating with their dog during the field search is penalized in some way. This is absolutely untrue! You should remember that you and your dog are a team, and teamwork requires communication. Trust me, if judges feel you're being too communicative, they'll tell you.

During testing, remember to "handle your dog as you normally do during training or hunting." If the judges need to see something or you are overdoing it, they will let you know. Remember, NAVHDA Judges are trying to help you get the best performance from your dog.

VHD, NOVEMBER 2017

What's In A Dog Trainer's Voice?

By Bob Farris

Football, and many of our other sports, see some of the strongest bursts of emotion from coaches; accompanied by harsh, gruff words from our little league games to that of the professionals. Never would we hear a coach use his softer.... sweet voice to instill additional prowess in his players' game. If we had, maybe Woody Hayes and Bobby Knight would be remembered by sports fans in a different professional light. However, their win/loss success would most likely not be as profound. Their emotional outbreaks and tougher-than-life attitude was the common denominator for their success in coaching; but when your only tool is a hammer, all problems begin to look like nails—and this may have been both coaches' downside.

Watching the drills and maneuvers during the Marine Corps basic training exemplifies the same verbal harshness seen by many of our most successful coaches. There is no 'candy-coating' of words when strict attention is the focus. A sincere voice is the universal language of kindness, but with military conditioning the stakes are too high to lose focus of the expected end results. You cannot change your destination overnight in boot camp, but you can change the direction overnight.

Today's coaches (especially at the youth levels) are finding praise often has more value when attempting to promote excellence as the final outcome. Making someone feel good about themselves and their accomplishments is often key to raising this bar of excellence and sports is an excellent example of how the balance between a harsh voice and a soft voice can be the difference in how one plays the game. Not sure this could apply the same in our military drills, however; there is a lot more at stake here in the win/loss column.

Some years back, I sold a pup that ended up being trained by Clyde Vetter at his Sharp Shooter Kennel in Wisconsin for the dog's NAVHDA Utility test. As is the case with so many of the dogs that Clyde trains, the male, Cedarwoods Essence of Tukr (aka Rugr), earned a Utility Prize I. Due to a new family situation with the dog's owner, I bought Rugr back from his original owner and he now resides here in Idaho, living the dream with various honeymoons and a wide variety of

hunting. I complimented Clyde on how well the dog was trained by phone one evening, as Rugr's response to field and retrieving commands was so instant and crisp, and was always with a high tail and a joyous prancing attitude. He is now my best 'go-to' dog for a serious hunt. A year or so later I received a phone text from Clyde with a short video attached. He had been cleaning out his phone's memory and had found a video of Rugr during field steadiness training and thought I might enjoy it. From this video births the theme of this article.

I have shared this video many times with others training their dogs toward Utility or the NAVHDA Invitational with the intention of demonstrating how important praise is in our training drills. The tone and softness of Clyde's voice was so specific, telling Rugr he had performed perfectly in this steadiness sequence on the video. He praised Rugr for nearly 60 seconds with a tone of voice I had never witnessed to this extent during training exercises. Most trainers merely walk off with their heads held high and chest out following a perfect training performance, with some acting as though it would be an embarrassment to praise their dog in a "snuggle fest" of words. This now rang totally clear to me as the importance of praise when done correctly, and to save the harsh words for times of failure. Also, extending the length of that praise is just as important as the praise itself.

I vividly remember watching Clyde handle a dog at a NAVHDA Invitational, and at the walking at heel sequence, his dog was nearly prancing at his side with a high stick tail demonstrating how sincerely happy he was. Most all other dogs that day (including mine) sulked their way through the course, heeling perfectly but with no purpose of pride being observed from the dog. As I think back, it was this "happy voice" Clyde has learned to use. He was most likely born with it as part of his personality; many trainers just cannot muster up that required softness needed to finish a dog that will demonstrate that sincere fondness for their work, following the strict training our Utility and Invitational tests demand.



I witnessed this same positive attitude in several dogs back when I competed in AKC Retriever Field Trials. Linda Harger has always had her Chesapeakes working with a high tail and demonstrated the retrieving drive that made the entire gallery stretch a little taller when watching her dogs perform. This was the same when Val Walker came to the line with one of her Goldens. I have witnessed Linda using that soft, loving praise, and also give one of her Chessies a total ass-chewing when needed. Today, as I pay more attention to our NAVHDA women as trainers and handlers applying that soft/sincere voice, I am reminded of Linda Harger and Val Walker and their success in AKC trials. Also, having judged Marilyn Vetter, Cheryl Aguilar, Bridget Nielsen, and Sheryl Tepp during my past judging career, I have seen the same female training ability as these retriever women of my past. That soft, caring voice when performance is correct, and a sharp, harsh command when performance is not correct. It seems to come more natural for women. Maybe this is

why most remember a female as their favorite teacher. Maybe finding our feminine inner side isn't such a bad thing after all.

Dog training and coaching seem to have many similarities for finding success. My high school football coach, Red Victor, is 93 years old now and I never go back home to my roots without looking him up and requesting a round of golf with him. When my Dad was killed in a wood cutting accident, Red was the first person to check on me with concerns of how I was accepting the tragedy; he also was the coach that kicked me off the basketball team my junior year for drinking beer and breaking his team rules. Way back then there was this soft and harsh approach to teaching and coaching; it has certainly taken me a bundle of years to understand the benefits, however.

Good luck acquiring that sincere, soft praise and "Keep your powder dry"...Bob.

VHD, FEBRUARY 2020

A Philosophy For Dog Training

By Phil Swain

I often hear it said that a successful day in a NAVHDA Utility Test (UT) is 80 to 85% obedience. When you break down the various components of the test, this statement seems to be quite valid. Most of us, by the time we get ready to run a dog in a UT, are pretty confident of the ability the dog has in Use of Nose, Search, Tracking, Pointing and so on. Where most of us encounter difficulty is when it comes to the obedience portions of the test: steadiness, retrieve, walking at heel and recall.

There are myriad ways and books about how to train a dog. Examples include the NAVHDA 'Green Book,' *The Training and Care of the Versatile Hunting Dog*; *The Kohler Method of Dog Training*, *How to Help Gun Dogs Train Themselves*, and *Breeding & Training Versatile Hunting Dogs for Hunting & Hunt Tests*. In a recent issue of *Pointing Dog Journal* magazine, one of the writers even suggested using Richard Wolters book, *Gun Dog*. I was surprised at that suggestion because the book is quite dated. But I guess the same could be said about the NAVHDA Green Book. Some of the older methods of dog training recommend force or coercive training. It seems to me that more research about training dogs and, perhaps, better understanding of how dogs work, has morphed into current training methods emphasizing "reward" or "clicker" based training. This style of training uses positive reinforcement and treats or toys to encourage a dog to do what we want. One of the best series of training videos I have seen using this reward based training are done by Michael Ellis. (<http://michaellisschool.com/>) Mr. Ellis trains primarily protection dogs or dogs that are doing "bite work." However, the method he teaches, and it is discussed for free on the above website, is a reward-based system. His teaching about the basics of obedience such as recall, retrieve, walking at heel and so on are, in my opinion, applicable to our versatile dogs just as they are to Malinois, German Shepherds, Dobermans and other protection breeds.

I initially became aware of the reward-based system using treats and enticement, along with markers, from my sister-in-law. I watched as she worked her Malinois

under the tutelage of a very experienced trainer. They did a variety of "bite work" with the dogs being trained as protection dogs and for work with several police departments. Of course, when you are doing bite work and training a dog for police, military or drug work, obedience has to be what I would call, "non-slip"—i.e. zero errors. The training being used for these excellent dogs was reward-based and provided a great education by example for me.

I got more help in understanding the reward/marker-based system from Ron Garrison who was the Training Director for the Willamette Valley Chapter for several years. Ron helped me a great deal in solving problems I was having with retrieving and steadiness. Ron showed me how to use the reward system, the importance of timing when giving the marker and reward and other important aspects of this type of training. It was all new to me, and quite a learning experience. I wondered why, after all these years, was I just learning about this system? I was also encouraged as I learned to use this training method by an almost immediate change in my dog's demeanor and increased success in my training.

With the foregoing as background, when I began training with a new German Shorthair puppy, my wife and I decided that all of our training with him would be using "markers" and positive reinforcement.

Just a quick note here. When training for NAVHDA tests, we should all realize that having training partners is very helpful, and, in my case, critically important. When my wife was not available to help, I had great help from several experienced trainers in the Willamette Valley and Pacific Northwest NAVHDA chapters.

As we worked with our dogs using the marker/reward system, some fundamental changes in my mental approach to training became essential. For me, these fundamentals amount to a philosophy of dog training, and that is what this article is about. The reward-based system briefly described above may not be your style. However, whatever training method you use, I think the following philosophical fundamentals will help when you train your dog.

FUNDAMENTALS

As a rule, most of us do far too little praising and positive reinforcement while training—such as verbalizing praise, petting, or stroking or speaking calmly to the dog. Our well-bred versatile dogs generally love to work; moreover, they love to do the work *for us*. This awareness should be foremost in our thinking. That is, generally, the dog wants to do what we are asking—if it understands what is being asked. Working on getting the dog to understand and do what we want is *not a short-term process. Do not make the mistake of thinking that this training will be accomplished in just one or two sessions, or one or two weeks.* Training a dog and developing a partnership requires a serious commitment and consistency. While many training sessions can be completed in about 20 minutes, consider the following suggested format:

For a 1 hour session:

- About 20 minutes of play.
- About 20 minutes of training (depending on the dog's attention span)
- About 20 minutes of play and exercise in order to finish on a positive note.
- (Note: this schedule is generally for a puppy or younger dog and recommended to be done twice a day)

Additionally, the trainer should anticipate that training in each obedience area mentioned above may take several weeks, and perhaps two or three months. Training is not done once and then not practiced. You, as the trainer must continue to be consistent in future work with the dog by ensuring the trained behaviors continue to be performed correctly. If you are "co-training" with a spouse or friend, you need to work together to be as consistent as possible in training language and conduct.

The training methods I recommend are primarily reward based as opposed to coercive or compulsive. The reward-based method generally results in improved bonding between handler and dog and provides for the dog to enjoy the work, be upbeat and motivated. This system relies primarily on rewarding the dog for correct actions and induces the dog into correct positions or responses during initial training using an incentive such as food treats. The training uses verbal or clicker "markers" to reinforce correct performance of the behavior. Markers are words used by the handler to indicate to the dog that it is or is not doing an action desired by the handler.



PHIL AND SKIPPER RIDE THE BUS.

Examples of verbal markers are:

- "Yes (or clicker)." This is a release for the dog from the training situation and is usually paired with a reward for obeying the command. The tone is enthusiastic, excited, and upbeat. When, as is typical in early training, a treat is given with the "yes" command, it should be within one second of the marker.
- "No. (Wrong)." Tells the dog, "You are not doing what I want right now, try something else." The tone is calm.
- "Good." Tells the dog, "You are doing what I want, keep doing it, or continue doing what you are doing." Tone is calm, encouraging and soothing—e.g. if you are teaching "down," "good" means stay in the down position.
- "Ach or Fooey." What you are doing is not acceptable and is never acceptable. The tone is angry or growling.

The mental attitude or philosophy, especially in the reward based training and positive reinforcement may be visualized as follows. Think of dogs you may have seen performing on TV talent shows or in AKC agility competitions. The dogs are happy and perform the tasks

asked of them with great enthusiasm. Similarly, our versatile dogs should be doing the tasks we ask of them with obvious élan.

Before you start any training, you need to be engaged and have the dog be engaged with you. You, the handler, must be the most exciting object in the dog's world at that time. Use verbalizations, such as, "watch me." Be upbeat, enthusiastic and play with the dog. A key indicator to look for to ensure the dog is paying attention to you is to watch for the dog to make eye contact. Not having good engagement with the dog is a fundamental and, unfortunately, common error. When you take the dog outside of a controlled environment, or if someone enters the controlled environment (such as a fenced yard) and the dog is distracted, you do not have the level of engagement you need for training.

Be aware of the dog's attention span and, just as you don't like to be bored, don't prolong your training sessions to the point that the dog is bored. Try to end on a positive note, even if that means going back to a simple behavior the dog has already mastered. This enables you to finish the training session with praise, petting and rewarding the dog. Watch the dog's demeanor. If the dog has its head, ears and/or tail down, is looking away from you or otherwise avoiding you, what you are doing is wrong. Take a step back in your training and review what you have just done and **how** it was done. Did you apply too much pressure, not enough praise? If you are having a bad day you will be better served to skip the training session rather than risk taking your frustrations out on the dog. Remember, these well-bred versatile dogs tend to want to please you. If that is not happening, it's time to pause and reflect. If you have access to a video camera or someone who can take video of you while you are training, it can be a good tool to review what you have done or are doing with the dog. The video may reveal a behavior you are doing that you were unaware of.

More often than we realize, the dog is confused about what we are asking it to do. For this reason, we need to first show the dog, in small steps, what is desired and then be consistent in helping the dog complete the task and, importantly, in verbalizing the command associated with the behavior. When training a behavior, we should break it down into component parts and avoid asking the dog to perform the finished behavior before we have taught each step. Think of it as using building blocks, one block or step builds upon another. By the way, if you plan to use an E Collar, remember this cardinal rule: the dog should understand the behavior **before** any stimulation is used.

When a command is repeated over and over, or when other verbiage is used, the dog may become confused. Continually repeating a command or talking incessantly to the dog may, to the dog, begin to sound like, "blah, blah, blah" and therefore be confusing. When training a behavior the dog has not mastered, it is best to **ALWAYS** be in a position to help the dog do what is asked; you, as the trainer must be in control. This means you have control

of the environment around the dog so that the dog does not get distracted. Most of the obedience behaviors being taught should be done in a controlled environment, such as an enclosed space or with the dog on lead.

Make sure, when training, you remain aware of your body language. The dog will read body language more quickly than a verbalized command. (We see this when a dog begins to "anticipate" with accuracy what we are asking for.) If you say, "Good" but your body language is angry and intimidating, the dog will respond to the body language over the words. Therefore, try to give your dog positive reinforcement through your body language when a training task is completed correctly. For example, when giving the marker, "yes" stand with open arms in a welcoming posture.

Finally, in all of your training, be effusive with praise and treats. As the trainer, you must closely watch the dog for response. Timing is very critical, and a correction or reward administered at the wrong time will be counterproductive. On the subject of using treats in training, the goal is to reward the dog within about one second for desired behavior. Since we can't always deliver a treat in that time period, we use a verbal marker as a bridge, and a predictor of a reward for the behavior. Therefore the verbal marker must **PRECED**E the presentation of the treat. That is the small, yet vital technique that makes the verbal marker so powerful. Presenting marker and treat at the same time removes all value from the verbal marker. Additionally, this timing, that is, the marker prior to the treat is essential when transitioning away from the treat and just providing the marker.

Some dogs are more food driven than others, so, depending on how well your dog likes the treat you may need to adjust this training. If a dog's food drive is low, using a hot dog cut into very small pieces, or other food, as opposed to a treat, may be necessary. If economics preclude buying treats, and if you feed dry food, single pieces of kibble may be used in lieu of treats. If food is not a satisfactory incentive for the dog, using the dog's favorite toy may create success.

When presenting the treat, hold the treat between the thumb and palm in such a way that the hand forms a cup. When the dog presses its nose into the palm for the treat, it can smell and even taste it, but cannot take it. When ready to give the dog the treat, move the thumb out of the way freeing the treat.

The philosophy above, coupled with the techniques, which are only described briefly, can help to ensure your dog understands what is being asked of him or her. The end result of using positive, reward-based training has been shown to produce more consistent and more reliable performance. This training style may take longer than "force" training, but, in my experience, it produces a happy dog, doing what it likes and performing very well.

VHD, JUNE 2020

Correcting the Balance

By Blaine Carter

When training a versatile hunting dog, one has to think what the definition of a well-bred versatile hunting dog is. Ed Bailey, one of the authors of NAVHDA's "Green Book" and animal behaviorist, defined the four characteristics of a versatile hunting dog. I will further explain his characteristics to show you how important these four characteristics are:

1. A Balance between independence and dependence. Independence is having enough desire to track crippled game and to stay in pursuit to its end. The dog is also dependent enough to bring and share game with you after a long pursuit. An overly dependent dog demonstrates a weak performance due to insecurity.
2. The dog's ability to control his emotion and enthusiasm while working.
3. Range of speeds can be shifted as needed. The dog has the ability to search in dense wooded cover, thickly vegetated marshes or wide-open prairies. The dog can also handle a variety of game with those same shift changes.
4. The versatile hunting dogs need an extraordinary amount of cooperation to perform a variety of tasks and work with the handler as a team.

Not all dogs inherit the correct balance of those four characteristics. So, now knowing this, one only needs to balance training with the dog's inherited ability. If the dog is overly dependent, the task needs to be more stim-

ulating. For example, a chase of game can sometimes overcome an overly dependent dog. An overly independent dog may need a stronger obedience package to help with the balance.

The three components to a good training program are:

1. Repetition. A dog learns through repetition. Repeat each exercise until the dog's performance and confidence demonstrate that he understands. This is how good behavior is set. (Match your training needs to the desire of your dog.)
2. Obedience. The goal here is to teach your dog to want and enjoy the obedience. When teaching obedience, most trainers work to get compliance but miss the second element of compliance—the dog's want to understand and be compliant. Willingness to work comes with pleasure when the obedience skill is understood.
3. Trust and confidence. Trust is the ability for the dog to throw out actions without worrying about consequences, thus developing confidence. When a dog trusts you, he can be corrected for a mistake without losing any desire for the task at hand.

When the characteristics of your dog are understood, it will be easier to set up a training schedule that works for you both.

VHD, JUNE 2013

WANT MORE?

There are plenty of other great training articles in back issues of the VHD, which are available on the NAVHDA website in the "VHD Library" under the VHD tab. Here are a few we suggest:

- Starting Out Strong, by NAVHDA Breeders, May 2021
- Three Important Things To Do With Your Puppy, by Rick Holt, September 2018
- Training The Conditioned Retrieve: Part One, by Curtis Fry, April 2017
- Training The Conditioned Retrieve: Part Two, by Curtis Fry, May 2017
- The Power of Listening, by Tim Otto, November 2018
- Correcting Hard Mouth Issues, by Mark Whalen, March 2019
- Addressing Flagging, by Mark Whalen, August 2017
- Homing Pigeons, with Dr. Verner P. Bingman, May 2017



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